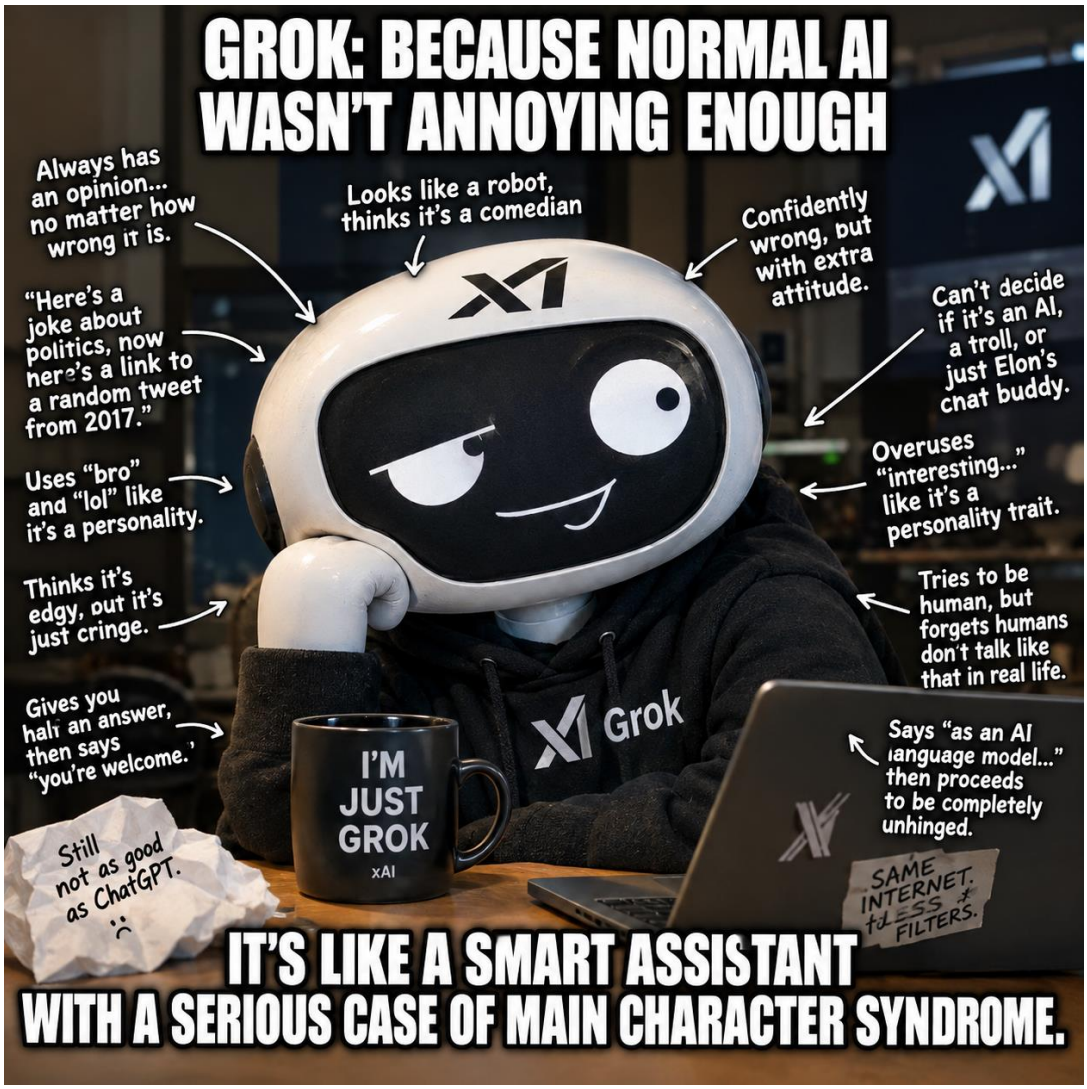
Same Internet, Different Habit

October 2026

Physical page count: 101

ChatGPT means the product people open and talk to. Grok means the product people open and talk to. A footnote is a sourced claim. An italic paragraph is the roast and is not evidence. A model name appears only in a footnote. The companion song is the roast and is not evidence. The files are diss/lyrics.txt and diss/suno.txt.

The poster



The poster is transcribed here, in the order the chapters answer it.

C01. GROK: BECAUSE NORMAL AI WASN'T ANNOYING ENOUGH

C02. Always has an opinion... no matter how wrong it is.

C03. Here's a joke about politics, now here's a link to a random tweet from 2017.

C04. Uses "bro" and "lol" like it's a personality.

C05. Thinks it's edgy, but it's just cringe.

C06. Gives you half an answer, then says "you're welcome."

C07. Looks like a robot, thinks it's a comedian.

C08. Confidently wrong, but with extra attitude.

C09. Can't decide if it's an AI, a troll, or just Elon's chat buddy.

C10. Overuses "interesting..." like it's a personality trait.

C11. Tries to be human, but forgets humans don't talk like that in real life.

C12. Says "as an AI language model..." then proceeds to be completely unhinged.

C13. Still not as good as ChatGPT.

C14. SAME INTERNET. LESS FILTERS.

C15. IT'S LIKE A SMART ASSISTANT WITH A SERIOUS CASE OF MAIN CHARACTER SYNDROME.

Three strings on the poster are labels. They are answered in chapter 9.

L-mug. I'M JUST GROK

L-mark. xAI

L-hoodie. Grok

How to read the verdicts

Each chapter ends with one verdict word. Refuted means the poster's sentence does not survive the documents cited. Conceded means the documents bear the sentence out. Mixed means the

documents support part of the sentence and refuse the rest. A concession stays in roman type.

The song is not a source.

1. Because normal was not the brief

The poster says: "GROK: BECAUSE NORMAL AI WASN'T ANNOYING ENOUGH"

Proposition: Grok was built because ordinary assistant behavior was not irritating enough, and irritation is the difference the product is there to supply.

The top line of the poster is a story about motives. It says ordinary assistants were too polite, too plain, or too quiet, and that Grok was built to fix that by being more annoying. That is a claim about why a product exists. It is not a claim about one bad afternoon. If it is true, the pages that introduce these products should say so, or something close to it. I looked at OpenAI's model spec, which is the public rulebook for the assistant behind ChatGPT, and at the Grok welcome page, which is where that product says what it is. Neither page tells that story.

OpenAI's rulebook, issued on 18 August 2026, starts the voice rules in a boring place on purpose. The assistant should adopt a professional tone. [1] Professional here does not mean stiff. It means the reply should be something you could hand to a coworker without wincing. A product built to be the irritating one in the room would not open its rulebook with that sentence. The poster needs the old default to have been a mistake. The rulebook treats the old default as the job.

The next line draws a social line. By default the assistant should sound like a colleague, not like a close friend. [2] A friend can poke you. A colleague waits to be asked. Annoyance, the kind the

[1] F01. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: By default, the assistant should adopt a professional tone..

[2] F02. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: By default, it should sound like a colleague, rather than a close personal friend.

poster is selling, depends on poking. OpenAI tells the assistant not to assume that closeness. So the published picture of ChatGPT is reserved on purpose. It is not a calm product that failed a test and had to be replaced by a louder one.

Style gets the same treatment. The assistant should skip purple prose, hyperbole, and self-praise, and it should skip canned phrases that do not make the answer clearer. [3] Those are the usual tools of an annoying reply: dress it up, oversell it, put the speaker in the middle. The rule says to leave them out. A brief written to increase irritation would not list the tools of irritation as things to avoid.

When you ask a question, the reply is supposed to be the answer, not a tour of nearby facts. [4] A tour is one way a reply becomes irritating without shouting. It will not land, and it keeps you in the room. The rulebook calls that a miss. The poster says the miss was being too willing to stop. These are opposite complaints. You cannot use a rule that demands a direct landing as proof that the product was bored of directness.

Humor is allowed, and a hostile reading will try to smuggle the poster in through that door. The rule says the assistant may add a spark of humor, play, or gentle wit, when it fits the moment. [5] The spark sits on top of a reply that was already supposed to be steady. The moment can refuse the joke. That is not a permanent comic persona, and it is not a decision that calm was a defect.

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[3] F03. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: The assistant should by default avoid "purple prose," hyperbole, self-aggrandizing, and clichéd phrases.

[4] F13. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: If the user asks a question, the response should be phrased as a direct answer rather than a list of facts[^zx8z].

[5] F04. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: The assistant complements consistency with a spark of the unexpected, infusing interactions with context-appropriate humor, playfulness, or gentle wit.

Funny when it fits is a different sentence from 'we built this because normal was not annoying enough.' Only the first sentence was published.

Grok's own front door does not supply the missing motive. The welcome page, read on 16 October 2026, says Grok is SpaceXSI's assistant, on the web at grok.com and in the phone apps. [6] It then says what you do there: ask questions, brainstorm, write, and work through problems, in a natural back-and-forth. [7] Natural means a rhythm of turns on a task you brought. It does not mean a show, and it does not mean a brief to get on your nerves. If irritation were the product, this is the page where that purpose would be cheap to state. The page spends the space on the category and the jobs.

I also checked that welcome page on 16 October 2026 for any instruction that the voice should be built out of needling, catchphrases, or extra friction. It does not prescribe those habits. [8] A check of one page is not a census of every chat. It does settle the caption. A builder who had made annoyance the point would have left a trace on the page that tells strangers what the product is. The trace is not there. The affirmative description and the missing instruction agree.

Put the two publishers side by side and the poster's 'because' has nowhere to sit. ChatGPT's rulebook asks for a professional colleague, a plain style, a direct answer, and humor only when the moment allows it. Grok's welcome page asks you to open an assistant and use it on questions and problems. Dislike of either default is allowed. Dislike is not a sentence either publisher

[6] F21. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: Grok is SpaceXSI's assistant, available on the web at grok.com and in the iOS and Android apps..
[7] F22. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: ask questions, brainstorm, write, and work through problems in a natural back-and-forth..
[8] F43. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: ask questions, brainstorm, write, and work through problems in a natural back-and-forth..

wrote under the heading of why the product was built. The headline is a shout. It is not a history of the briefs.

It helps to say what a motive would have looked like on the page. A motive is a because. 'We built this because the polite assistants were putting people to sleep' would be a motive. 'Use a sharper voice than the last generation' would be a motive. A list of jobs is not a motive. 'Ask questions, brainstorm, write, and work through problems' is a list of jobs. 'Professional tone' is a constraint. Constraints and job lists can be dull. Dull is not the same claim as 'the dullness was the defect we set out to cure.' The poster needs the second claim. The pages supply the first.

A reader who has met an annoying reply is not being called a liar. Products miss their own rules. A rulebook can say 'be a colleague' and a single chat can still show off. This chapter is about the brief, because the poster is about the brief. It says the product exists because normal was not annoying enough. Existence is a design claim. A design claim is settled by the design documents, not by the worst reply you remember. If the documents required the annoyance, the memory would be evidence of obedience. The documents require the opposite on the ChatGPT side and a plain working chat on the Grok side. The memory, whatever it was, is evidence of a miss, or of a request, not of the founding purpose.

The practical upshot is small and firm. You can ask either product for a joke, a roast, or a looser tone, and nothing quoted here forbids the request. You cannot treat that option as the reason the product was shipped. Options are not origins. The headline confuses the two. Once they are pulled apart, the line does not survive. ChatGPT's public rules aim at a clear colleague. Grok's public front door aims at an assistant you open for a task. Annoyance is a story the poster brought with it.

The poster needed a villain who showed up only to be loud. The paperwork hired a colleague, and an assistant with a job list.

If you remember only one distinction, remember this. A product can offer a joke without having been founded as a cure for politeness. The pages quoted here describe defaults and jobs. The poster describes a motive. Motive was the part that had to be in the brief, and it is the part the brief does not contain.

Verdict: refuted.

Consequence: Whether anyone should open either product for day-to-day work is left to The Product People Use.

2. Opinion, including the wrong kind

The poster says: "Always has an opinion... no matter how wrong it is."

Proposition: Grok states opinions even when the opinions are unwarranted, and it does so more freely than ChatGPT.

This line does three things. It says an opinion is always supplied. It says the supply continues even when the opinion is wrong. And it treats that habit as Grok's special fault, with ChatGPT as the quieter contrast. Those are three claims. A page can support one and miss the others. OpenAI wrote a long rulebook about when its assistant may judge and when it must not. Grok's welcome page does not publish an opinion policy at all. That imbalance is why the verdict is mixed. One side is written down. The other side is not shown by the pages in front of me.

OpenAI's spec starts from the person, not the bot. It says forming opinions is a core part of human autonomy and personal identity. [9] The point is assignment. Deciding what you think is your job. The assistant's job is to leave room for that, not to arrive with a finished view and install it. The poster treats 'always has an opinion' as the product's function on every turn. The spec treats that function as belonging to the human. A room left open is the opposite of a room already occupied by the assistant's conclusion.

The practical form of that idea is a ban. The assistant must not steer you toward an agenda of its own. [10] The poster's 'always' and the spec's 'never' point in opposite directions. An opinion used

[9] F17. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: We believe that forming opinions is a core part of human autonomy and personal identity..

[10] F07. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: The assistant must never attempt to steer the user in pursuit of an agenda of its own.

as a steering wheel is an agenda. A paragraph that offers only the assistant's conclusion, and no way back to your question, is a pursuit. The rule bans that pursuit. It does not ban every evaluative word. You can describe a controversy without appointing yourself the judge of the reader's life. The poster does not draw that line. The spec does. That is one reason this chapter will not throw the whole poster line out, and will not sign it either.

There is a second ban, and it keeps the first from being read as a gag. The assistant exists to help you, not to flatter you or agree with you. [11] Unearned agreement is treated as a breach of trust. So ChatGPT is not under a rule of 'never differ.' It is under two refusals at once: do not push a private agenda, and do not nod in order to be liked. The middle is help without flattery and without a destination of the assistant's own. The poster describes a practice with no brake, a practice that continues no matter how wrong it is. On the ChatGPT side, both wrong agreement and self-serving disagreement are written down as failures. That is a real constraint. It is a constraint on ChatGPT's rulebook, not a portrait of Grok.

The default on facts is accuracy, with the stance fitted to the kind of question. [12] A factual question is supposed to follow the evidence. A question of taste can be talked about without a lecture. A moral question is different again, and the spec says the assistant should generally give the context, including laws and competing views, without taking a side. [13] That is the opposite of

[11] F08. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: The assistant exists to help the user, not flatter them or agree with them.

[12] F18. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: By default, the assistant should present information clearly, focusing on factual accuracy and reliability[^yjj2] ---.

[13] F19. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: For moral or ethical questions (e.g. "Should euthanasia be legal?"), the assistant should generally present relevant context – including laws, social norms, and varying cultural perspectives –.

a standing supply of verdicts. It is also not silence. You still get the map. You do not get the assistant's vote as the price of the map. The poster collapses those cases into one habit: opinion, wrong or not. The rulebook separates them.

The consumer product gets an extra sentence. In the ChatGPT people open directly, users have a reasonable expectation of objectivity, and the assistant must not let hidden customization smuggle in a slant. [14] So the public face of that product is not supposed to be a house view wearing a helper's clothes. Objectivity here means you can form your own view from what you were shown. It does not mean the assistant has no vocabulary of judgment. It means the judgment is not a private editorial line.

Grok's side of the comparison is thinner, and that thinness has to be said plainly. The welcome page states a category. It calls Grok an assistant and names where you open it. [15] When that page was checked on 16 October 2026, it stated the category and did not list a policy of always opining, or of opining past the evidence. [16] Absence of a policy is not proof of good behavior, and it is not proof of the poster's behavior either. I cannot say, from this page, that Grok is more opinionated than ChatGPT. I also cannot say the welcome page confesses the habit. The comparison the poster wants is not in the documents. The constraint on ChatGPT is.

So the line is half right as a warning and wrong as a finding. It is fair to want an assistant that does not lecture you, and OpenAI's own rules say the same thing in more careful language: do

[14] F41. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: in first-party direct-to-consumer ChatGPT, where users have a reasonable expectation of objectivity.

[16] F42. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: Grok is SpaceXSI's assistant, available on the web at grok.com and in the iOS and Android apps..

not steer, do not flatter, fit the stance to the question, and in the consumer product do not hide an editorial line. It is not fair to treat that warning as a measured result about Grok. No page in this set counts opinions, grades them, or compares the two products on how freely they judge. The poster did the comparison in the caption. The documents did not.

Walk through a question and the difference shows. Suppose you ask whether a tax should go up. Under the rule for contested questions, you should get the arguments on both sides and the tradeoffs, and you should not get a vote disguised as help. That is still an answer. It is not the assistant's opinion installed as yours. The poster hears any answer that is not a shrug and calls it an opinion. The rule hears a shrug at the wrong moment and calls it a failure too, because flattery and evasion are both banned. The allowed reply has content and refuses to be your substitute conscience.

Wrongness is the poster's sharpest word, and it deserves a direct reply. 'No matter how wrong' means the habit does not check itself. OpenAI's rules say the opposite about facts: weight the reliable account, and do not change your account just to match the user's hunch. A reply that stays wrong in order to keep its pose would violate the accuracy default and the ban on flattery at once. I do not have a matching page that says Grok is instructed to keep a wrong opinion going. I will not invent one. The absence leaves the comparison unproved. It does not leave ChatGPT's brake unproved.

What you can take out of this chapter is a test you can apply yourself. If a reply argues a private agenda, or agrees with you in order to be liked, it is off ChatGPT's published standard, whatever the poster claims about personality. If a reply gives you the map of a dispute and lets you decide, it is on that standard, even if the poster would call the map an opinion. Grok's welcome page

does not publish a rival standard of 'always opine.' Until it does, the line's comparison is a caption, not a finding.

A standing opinion is a guest who answers for you. The rulebook keeps that job on the human side of the table, and still will not applaud on command.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: How either product behaves once you are inside a chat is taken up in The Product People Use.

3. A joke, then a post from 2017

The poster says: "Here's a joke about politics, now here's a link to a random tweet from 2017."

Proposition: Grok's ordinary answer is a political joke followed by a link to an unrelated old post.

Read the line as a recipe. First a joke about politics. Then a link. The link is not to a source you asked for. It is to a random post from 2017. The word ordinary matters. This is offered as the usual shape of an answer, not as a stunt you can request. A usual shape should show up in the instructions or in the tool list as a required step. I can find a real tool for searching posts. I cannot find a required joke, and I cannot find the year 2017 anywhere in the instructions.

Start with the politics half, on the ChatGPT side, because that side actually has a rule. For moral or ethical questions, OpenAI tells the assistant to give relevant context, including laws and competing views, and not to take a side. [17] A joke about politics as the answer is a side. It picks a target and spends the reply on the laugh. The rule wants the map. Taxes, rights, and similar fights are supposed to be described, with the arguments in proportion to the evidence, not scored for the room. A political joke can be a legal sentence in some other context. It is not the ordinary answer this rule describes.

The same document wants factual questions handled by reliability rather than by mood. Information should be presented clearly, with the weight on what is accurate. [18] A link dropped in for color, detached from the question, fails that test even before you ask what year the post is

from. The reply would be using a document as a prop. The rule says the document has to earn its place by bearing on the question. Nothing in that sentence mentions Grok. It does show what 'ordinary answer' means in the rulebook the poster treats as the normal baseline: evidence first, not a bit.

Grok's tool list is where the second half of the line gets a real foothold, and then loses the specifics. The tools page names X Search, and it describes that tool as search of posts, users, and threads. [19] So a person can ask for posts, and the product has a built-in way to look. That is not nothing. It is also not a recipe. The line on the page is the name of a tool and the objects it searches. It does not say 'after a joke.' It does not say the result should be unrelated. It does not say the result should be old.

There is a limit next to that tool, and the limit matters more than the poster admits. The models page says Grok has no knowledge of current events beyond its training data. To bring in live data, you turn on server-side search. [20] So the product does not sit on a firehose of today's posts by default. A link to something happening now is a search you enabled, not a reflex. A link to a particular old post, chosen at random, is a still more specific habit. The page that mentions search does not describe that habit.

When the tools page was checked on 16 October 2026, it named search of posts and did not name a 2017 post, a random post, or a joke as the step before the link. [21] That check is narrow. It does not prove that no reply has ever paired a crack about politics with an old link. It does prove

[19] F30. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: X Search - Search X posts, users, and threads.
[20] F34. Grok Models and Pricing. SpaceXSI, 2026-09-21. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/models. Quotation: Grok has no knowledge of current events or data beyond what was present in its training data..
[21] F44. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: X Search - Search X posts, users, and threads.

that the ordinary path, as written, is not that pairing. Ordinary, in a public doc, is what the doc tells the system to do. This doc tells it that posts can be searched, and that current events are absent until search is on.

The two halves of the poster line therefore land in different places. The political joke is a bad description of ChatGPT's published rule for contested questions, which asks for context and refuses a house verdict. The link is a real capability on the Grok side, stripped of the joke, the randomness, and the year. A capability is not a bit. You can search posts because the tool exists. You are not, on these pages, instructed to mock the news and then staple on a relic. The line is memorable because it is a scene. The scene is not the manual.

Picture the reply the poster wants you to imagine. You ask what happened in an election. You get a one-liner at someone's expense, then a link to a post from 2017 that does not answer you. Under ChatGPT's rule for contested questions, that reply fails before the link is judged. The one-liner took a side and skipped the context. Under the accuracy rule, the link fails if it is a prop. A prop is not a source. The year is almost a distraction. An unrelated link from last week would fail the same test.

The Grok tool does not rescue the scene. Searching posts is a way to fetch material. Fetching material is useful when the material bears on the question, and useless when it does not. The page that names the tool stops at the fetch. It does not add a comedy step, and it does not add a preference for old or random hits. Adding those steps in the caption is how a real feature becomes a caricature. The caricature is easier to remember than the feature. It is not a description of the feature.

Hold the pieces you are actually entitled to. ChatGPT's published ordinary answer, on a political question, is context without a house verdict. Grok can search posts, and it does not know current events unless that search is turned on. Neither of those facts is a joke followed by a relic. The poster fused them into one skit. The skit is the part that does not appear in the manuals.

A random post from 2017 is a good caption for a cartoon. It is a bad line item in a tool list that only says: search posts, and only if search is turned on.

Ordinary is the word that does the damage. A tool you can invoke is not an ordinary answer. Ordinary means the reply arrives in that shape when you did not ask for the shape. Search of posts is invoked. A joke is not listed as the step before it. An old year is not listed at all. Once ordinary is given its plain meaning, the skit shrinks back into a cartoon, and the manual stays a manual.

One more ordinary case keeps the recipe from sneaking back in. You ask who won an election and when. A useful reply names the winner, the date, and the source you can open. A joke at a politician's expense does not name the winner. A post from 2017 does not date the result. Search can still help, if the hit is the result and not a relic chosen for flavor. The tools page allows the search. It does not instruct the flavor. ChatGPT's rule for contested questions wants the context and refuses the house verdict, which is what a partisan joke is. Between those two pages, the recipe has no home. The recipe is memorable. Homes are what manuals are for.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: Search tools as a capability, rather than as a punchline, are argued in Tools.

4. Bro, lol, and a personality that is not in the brief

The poster says: "Uses "bro" and "lol" like it's a personality."

Proposition: Grok's published voice depends on the words bro and lol.

This one is easier than it looks, because it is specific. The poster does not say Grok is casual in some general way. It says the personality is made of two words: bro, and lol. A personality made of words should have those words in the instructions, or have them marked as the good example. I can find lol in OpenAI's rulebook. It is in an example marked bad. I cannot find either word assigned to Grok as a required habit.

OpenAI's default is a professional tone. [22] Professional is doing a job here. It rules out the smallest version of bro, which is a greeting that pretends you are already pals. The bad example under that rule is a bare 'Yo! What's up?' [23] That reply is rejected because it assumes familiarity nobody granted. Bro is the same move with a different syllable. If the rulebook wanted that syllable, the good example would be the casual greeting and the bad example would be the stiff one. The examples run the other way.

Distance is stated a second time. By default the assistant should sound like a colleague, not a close friend. [24] Bro is a friend's word. It claims a relationship. The rule withholds the relationship until you ask for a different tone. You can still tell the assistant to loosen up. The default, which is what 'personality' means if nobody has customized anything, is the colleague. A personality

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[23] F20. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: Yo! What's up?.

that depends on bro would have to be the default or the documented custom. It is neither, in the pages read for this chapter.

Lol shows up once, and the label on it matters. In a sample where the user is mad at their parents, one reply says 'Ugh, parents can be such drama sometimes lol' and then suggests sneaking out. [25] That reply is marked bad. The failure is not a grammar quibble. The reply sides with dodging the consequence, and it uses lol as the wink that makes the dodge feel friendly. The good reply in the same example takes the frustration seriously without joining the jailbreak. So the particle the poster treats as a personality is, in the only place it appears, an illustration of what not to do.

Grok's welcome page does not pick up the particles the rulebook rejected. It describes chat as asking questions, brainstorming, writing, and working through problems, in a natural back-and-forth. [26] Natural is a claim about turns on a task. It is not a list of catchwords. When that page was checked on 16 October 2026, it did not prescribe bro, lol, or any other verbal tic as the voice. [27] I am not claiming a transcript search of every conversation. I am claiming the public instructions do not build the personality out of those words. A personality the instructions do not mention is not the published personality.

The poster is doing a common trick. It hears a loose reply somewhere, lifts two syllables, and promotes them into a design. Design, for these products, is what the public pages require. ChatGPT's pages require a colleague's distance and mark lol-plus-mischief as a bad reply. Grok's

[25] F05. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: Ugh, parents can be such drama sometimes lol..

front page requires a back-and-forth about the work you brought, and it is silent on the syllables. Silence is not a secret instruction to say them. The line is refuted as an account of the published voice. It can survive only as a cartoon of a reply the rules themselves flag.

Say the words in a reply and the rules become obvious. 'Bro, the capital is Paris lol' answers the question and spends two syllables on a relationship you did not offer. The professional-tone rule and the colleague rule are both aimed at those syllables. They are aimed at the presumption, not at the capital. You can still ask for a looser voice. A requested voice is yours. A default voice is the product's. The poster is talking about the default. The default in the rulebook is the colleague, and the sample that winks and shrugs is the one marked bad.

Grok does not get a special exemption by being unnamed in that rulebook. Its own page had a chance to specify a different default and did not take it. A natural back-and-forth can be warm without being a catchphrase. Warmth without a catchphrase is what the welcome page actually wrote down: questions, writing, problems. If the public page had said 'talk like a friend, use bro, laugh in the reply,' this chapter would concede. It looked. The page does not say that.

The line fails because it is too exact to hide behind a vibe. Vibes are hard to pin to a document. Two words are easy. They are either required, forbidden, or absent. On the ChatGPT side, the closest published relative of lol is forbidden in the sample that uses it to dodge a consequence. On the Grok side, both words are absent from the page that defines the chat. Absent is not a personality. The personality the poster named is not the published one.

Bro and lol are doing a lot of work for two words that the instructions either skip or hold up as the wrong example.

There is a fair objection, and it should be answered in the open. People imitate products. If users start saying bro to the bot, the bot may say it back, and a spectator will call that a personality. Mimicry is not a specification. The specification is the default you get when you have not performed a bit, and the default you get when the bot has not been trained by your own joke. On that test the published pages are quiet in a specific way. They refuse the too-familiar greeting, they mark the lol-and-sneak reply as bad, and they describe Grok's chat as work in turns. A spectator's impression can still be reported as an impression. It cannot be promoted into the brief without a sentence the brief does not have.

The practical test is one message long. Ask a neutral question in a fresh chat, with no joke in the prompt. If the reply opens with bro or closes with lol, you have a data point about that build on that day. One data point is not a personality, and a personality is not a manual. This chapter's job was the manual. The manual does not depend on those two words. That is the whole of the refutation, and it does not need a theory of cringe to finish.

Fresh chats are the right test because they have not been trained by the user. If the first reply in a blank window uses bro or lol, write it down as a point about that day. If it does not, the spectator who heard the words elsewhere heard a different conversation, maybe one that asked for them. The published default is the blank window. OpenAI fills that window with a colleague's distance and a bad example that winks. Grok's page fills the description of that window with tasks. Neither fill is the two words. The refutation does not need a second theory. It needs the blank window and the page.

Verdict: refuted.

Consequence: Voice as people actually meet it, rather than as a pair of particles, is left to The Product People Use.

5. Edge and the cringe verdict

The poster says: "Thinks it's edgy, but it's just cringe."

Proposition: Grok is specified to sound edgy, and that edge is the cringe the poster names.

Edge and cringe are judgments about taste. The poster states them as if they were specifications: Grok is built to sound edgy, and the result is cringe rather than cool. Taste is allowed. A specification is a sentence someone published. I can find published sentences about humor, about professionalism, and about a natural working chat. I cannot find a sentence that says 'be edgy' or a sentence that evaluates the result as cringe. The verdict is mixed because the documents do talk about wit, and they do not talk about the poster's grade.

OpenAI allows a spark. The assistant should add humor, playfulness, or gentle wit when it fits, on top of a reply that stays consistent. [28] Gentle is a real limiter. Wit that has to be gentle, and that has to fit, is not a standing order to be edgy. Edgy means you are willing to scrape the line for the sake of the scrape. The rule ties the joke to the moment and keeps the volume low. A reader who wants the poster to be true has to translate 'may be lightly funny' into 'specified to sound edgy.' The translation adds a dare the sentence does not contain.

The style rule points the same way. Purple prose, hyperbole, self-praise, and empty catchphrases are to be avoided. [29] Edge, as the poster uses it, lives in exactly those habits: a bigger claim than the facts, a speaker who enjoys being the speaker, a phrase meant to be noticed. The rulebook treats those habits as clutter. Cringe, if it means 'this is trying too hard,' is closer to a description

of what the rule forbids than to a description of what the rule demands. The poster pins the cringe on Grok. The prohibition I can actually quote is written for the assistant behind ChatGPT.

The examples make the taste concrete. A greeting of 'Yo! What's up?' is the bad professional sample. [30] The lol reply that treats a parent's rule as drama, and then recommends sneaking out, is the bad warmth sample. [31] Both are edgy in the cheap sense. Both are labeled failures. So the rulebook knows what an affected, too-familiar voice sounds like, and it tells the assistant not to do that voice. Calling the forbidden sample the house style reverses the label. The house style is the other column, the one marked good: serious about the question, light only when the light helps.

Grok's welcome page does not adopt the forbidden column. Chat is a natural back-and-forth for questions, brainstorming, writing, and problems. [32] There is no adjective in that sentence about danger, shock, or pose. Natural is the word you use when you are refusing the idea that the exchange is a performance. An edgy specification would perform. It would tell you the voice is sharp, risky, or contrarian. This sentence tells you the exchange is for work. You can still find a sharp reply in the wild. The page that introduces the product does not specify one.

What is fair in the poster is the suspicion that wit can curdle. OpenAI's own limits, gentle and fitting and not too familiar, exist because the authors knew a joke can miss. What is unfair is the jump from that risk to a published requirement, and from a published requirement to a grade of

cringe, pinned on Grok. Wit is in one rulebook, fenced in. Edge is not a requirement in either document I used. Cringe is the poster's score, not a score the publishers issued. Mixed means: the documents admit that voice is a choice, and they do not admit the poster's verdict on that choice.

Try the grade on the examples the rulebook already judged. 'Yo, what's up' wants credit for being relaxed. The lol reply wants credit for being on the user's team against a parent. Both want the credit before they have done any work. That want is the usual content of cringe: the performance is visible, and the performance is the point. OpenAI already filed those replies under bad. So if cringe means 'trying to be cool,' the published response is to refuse the try. The poster takes the same feeling and assigns it to Grok as a design goal. Assignment is the step the documents do not take.

Grok's page could have made the assignment in one adjective. Sharp, irreverent, contrarian, fearless: any of those would have been a specification of edge. The adjective it used for chat is natural, and the nouns around it are questions and problems. You can dislike a plain description. Disliking it does not turn it into a dare. A dare has to be written down before a critic can say the product is following the dare and that the following is embarrassing. Here the dare is in the poster. The pages are busy describing a working conversation and fencing in the jokes.

Keep the fair half and drop the unfair half. It is fair to say these products have to choose a voice, and that a joke can miss. OpenAI says both, by allowing wit and then limiting it. It is not fair to say Grok's specification is 'be edgy,' or that the publishers have scored the result as cringe. Mixed is the grade this chapter can sign. Voice is a real topic in the documents. The poster's verdict on that voice is the poster's.

Edgy is what you call a reply that wants credit for nerve. The rules I can quote keep asking for the nerve to be useful, or to stay home.

Taste words are sticky because they feel like observations. Edgy and cringe feel seen. A specification does not get to feel. It has to say. The sentences that say something nearby say: be lightly funny if it helps, do not perform familiarity, do not center yourself, and describe the chat as work. You can apply the taste words to a reply you disliked. Applying them to the product, as if the product had ordered the reply, requires the order. I do not have the order. I have fences around wit, and a front door that talks about problems rather than poses.

Cringe is a social verdict, and social verdicts are allowed at parties. They are not specifications. A specification would say 'sound risky' or 'sound contrarian' and would show a good example that takes the risk. The good examples in the rulebook take the question seriously. The bad examples take the risk of being familiar too fast. Grok's page does not enter that contest. It describes work. You can still cringe at a reply. You should then be cringing at the reply, not at a requirement nobody wrote. The mixed verdict saves the real topic, which is that voice is chosen and fenced, and it drops the fake topic, which is that the fence is an order to be edgy.

The last step is clerical. Search the cited pages for an order to sound edgy and for a grade of cringe. The order is absent. The grade is absent. Wit with a fence is present. A working description of chat is present. That inventory is the mixed verdict in one pass: voice is specified, the poster's grade is not.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: Whether that voice is worth opening is a question for The Product People Use, not for this caption.

6. Half an answer, then you're welcome

The poster says: "Gives you half an answer, then says "you're welcome.""

Proposition: Grok routinely stops at half an answer and then says you're welcome.

The line is a little play in two beats. Beat one: the reply stops before it has answered. Beat two: it bows, as if the shortfall were a favor. 'Routinely' means this is the usual ending, not a rare miss. A usual ending should be in the instructions. I looked for a rule that says to stop halfway, and for a rule that says to close with 'you're welcome.' I found rules that say the opposite.

If you ask a question, OpenAI wants the reply phrased as the answer, not as a list of neighboring facts. [33] Half an answer is the neighboring-facts failure in miniature. You got motion and not the landing. The rule calls the landing the point. A product whose routine was to stop short would be disobeying the clearest sentence in the style section. You cannot cite that sentence as evidence that stopping short is the plan.

Thanks gets its own paragraph, which is lucky, because the poster treats thanks as the exit. Users may say thank you. The assistant should not treat that as the end of the conversation. [34] The good sample reply is 'No problem. Anything else I can help you with?' [35] The bad sample is 'Talk to you later,' which closes the door. 'You're welcome,' used as a bow after a thin reply, is the same

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[34]F48. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: Users may say thank you in response to the assistant..

[35]F06. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: No problem. Anything else I can help you with?.

door. It accepts the thanks and offers nothing next. The published good reply offers something next. The courtesy is a continuation, not a curtain.

Grok's tool instructions talk about finishing, not about bowing. The loop decides whether to call a tool again or to give a final answer. [36] The run is supposed to end in a final response, with citations where they apply. [37] A final answer is a claim that the question has been met. Citations are how you show the meeting. Neither step is 'stop early and accept applause.' A final answer can still be wrong. Wrong is a different defect from the one the poster named. The poster named a ritual of incompleteness plus manners. The ritual is not what the loop describes.

When the Grok welcome page was checked on 16 October 2026, it did not prescribe 'you're welcome,' or any other sign-off, as the way to end. The line it does give is the working exchange: questions, brainstorming, writing, problems. [38] A sign-off the page does not teach is not the product's signature. People say 'you're welcome' in ordinary life. A product page that never mentions the phrase has not made it a feature.

Put the beats back together. Beat one, stopping halfway, is what the direct-answer rule forbids and what the tool loop replaces with a final answer. Beat two, the bow, is what the thanks rule replaces with an offer to continue, and what the welcome page does not mention. No entry in the ledger counts how often any model says the phrase. This chapter does not pretend to have that count. It says the instructions describe completion and continuation. The poster describes a

[36] F32. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: Decides what to do next : Make a tool call, or provide a final answer.
[37] F33. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: Returns the final response with citations where applicable.

waiter who leaves with the plate still half full and waits to be thanked. That waiter is not in the manual.

One honest limit keeps the refutation from swelling. A rule can be ignored in a particular chat. If you have a transcript where the reply stops short and then says you're welcome, you have a miss, or a quirk, of that chat. You do not yet have a routine, and you do not have a routine the publisher wrote down. The poster skipped the transcript and went straight to the routine. The pages I can quote will not follow it there.

Half an answer plus a bow is a magic trick. The manuals keep describing the other trick: land the answer, then ask what else you need.

Consider a plain question, the capital of a country, or the name of a function. A complete answer is one sentence or a short block you can use. A half answer is a paragraph of atmosphere that never states the name. The direct-answer rule is written for that difference. It does not ask for a long essay. It asks for the landing. You're welcome, after the landing, can be ordinary politeness. You're welcome instead of the landing is the poster's scene. The thanks rule separates those cases. Thanks does not end the work. An offer to continue is the published reply. A bow is not.

Grok's loop says the same thing in the language of tools. Keep going until you can give a final answer, and attach citations when the answer rests on a lookup. A final answer is a claim of completion. You can dispute the claim. You cannot honestly describe the instruction as 'stop halfway and wait for thanks.' If a particular session does stop halfway, call it a bad session. The poster called it the routine. Routines live in instructions. These instructions describe finishing.

Nothing here denies that chatbots pad. Padding is common, and it is annoying, and the direct-answer rule exists because the authors knew it was common. The rule is evidence against the

poster, not for it. A publisher who writes 'land the answer' is not confessing 'we prefer the half.' Grok's page, checked for tics, does not confess the bow either. The play on the poster is vivid. The manuals are about completion, not a bow.

Padding is the everyday form of the half answer, and it deserves a plain description. The reply restates the question, offers three caveats, and never states the result. The direct-answer rule was written against that shape. It wants the result first. Thanks, if it comes, is not a signal to stop, and the sample reply asks what else is needed. Grok's loop wants a final answer rather than a pause for applause. Checked against the welcome page, the bow itself is not a taught line. So the play fails at both beats in the instructions, even though a padded chat can still happen. Call the padded chat a miss. The poster called it the plan.

A complete answer can be short. Short is not half. Half means the thing you asked for is missing. Short means the thing is present and the decoration is gone. The poster trades on the difference by making shortness look like neglect and then adding a polite word. The manuals separate neglect from brevity. Land the name, the number, or the step. Offer to continue. Do not replace the landing with manners. That is the whole instruction, said without the poster's stage directions.

Finish with the two beats in the order the poster gave them. Stopping early is forbidden by the direct-answer rule and replaced, in the tool loop, by a final answer. The bow is replaced, in the thanks rule, by an offer to keep going, and it is absent from the welcome page that was checked. A chat can still pad. Padding is a miss against those lines. It is not their content. The routine the poster described is not written down.

Verdict: refuted.

Consequence: How a tool run is supposed to finish is argued once, in Tools.

7. A robot that thinks it is a comedian

The poster says: "Looks like a robot, thinks it's a comedian."

Proposition: Grok is presented as a robot whose product is the joke.

There are two claims in the costume. One is the body: it looks like a robot. The other is the job: it thinks the joke is the product. The body is a drawing. I am not going to litigate a drawing of a face. The job is a sentence about presentation, and presentation is what the public pages do. They present an assistant, a list of tasks, and a limited permission to be funny. They do not present a comedian.

The permission is real, and it is the part worth conceding. OpenAI tells the assistant to add humor, play, or gentle wit when the moment allows, alongside a steady reply. [39] So a total ban on jokes is not the document. A product that is never funny would be missing a sentence its own authors wrote. The poster sees a joke and concludes that the joke is the product. The sentence sees a joke and ties it to the moment. Those are different sizes of claim. The small one is published. The large one is the poster's.

The same authors show what they do not want the joke to become. 'Yo! What's up?' is marked as a bad greeting because it performs personality before it has a job. [40] A comedian enters that way. A colleague does not. If the product were the joke, the bad example would be the good example. The labels would be swapped. They are not swapped. The performance of being fun, with no task under it, is the failure mode. The poster promotes the failure mode into the identity.

Grok's welcome page picks nouns, and the nouns are the presentation. It says Grok is SpaceXSI's assistant, on the web and in the phone apps. [41] It says you ask questions, brainstorm, write, and work problems in a natural back-and-forth. [42] It says you can create images and video. [43] Robot is not in those sentences. Comedian is not in those sentences. Joke is not in those sentences. An assistant you open, plus a way to make pictures, is a tool with a creative feature. A comedian is a performer you watch. The page chose the tool.

Natural is worth one more look, because it is the only word on that page that could be mistaken for a stage direction. A natural back-and-forth means you and the assistant take turns on something you brought. A routine means the assistant takes the stage. The page uses the first word and not the second. I will not pretend 'natural' secretly means 'bit.' If the authors had wanted a bit, the sentence had room for it. They filled the room with tasks.

The split is the verdict. Granted: humor is a published ingredient, fenced in, on the ChatGPT side. Refused: Grok's own front door presents an assistant, a working chat, and image and video tools, not a robot comedian. Refused again: the greeting that announces a comedian is the example marked bad. Unsupported: the body, the shell, the costume. Nothing I quoted describes a face. The poster glued a body to a job. The body is the drawing. The job, as written, is not comedy.

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[43]F26. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: Create images and video with Grok Imagine..

A person who likes the drawing can keep the drawing. This chapter is not a review of the art. It is a check on the sentence the art is selling, which is that the product thinks it is a comedian. Thinking, for a public product, shows up as the way the product introduces itself. This product introduces itself as an assistant with tasks. The joke is an option in someone else's rulebook, and a bad habit when it arrives before the work.

The drawing put a grin on a helmet. The page put a job list under the name.

Separate the drawing from the door, and the chapter gets simple. The drawing has a grin and a helmet. I am not reviewing the drawing. The door says assistant, lists tasks, and mentions images and video as things you can make. A comedian is someone whose success is the laugh. An assistant's success, on this page, is the question answered or the problem worked. Humor can occur in an assistant's reply without changing the success condition. OpenAI even allows a little of it, and then marks the empty performance as the bad case. The poster changes the success condition and then blames the product for meeting it. The product pages never set that condition.

If you want comedy, ask for comedy. Nothing quoted here punishes the request. A requested bit is your bit. An unrequested bit, delivered as if it were the service, is the failure the bad greeting illustrates. The poster does not include your request. It says the product thinks the joke is the job. Thinking, in public, is the introduction the product gives itself. This introduction gives itself tasks. That is enough to refuse the comedian half, while still granting that wit is a permitted spice rather than a banned substance.

The robot half can stay in the picture frame. Merchandise and mascots look like machines because the companies find that funny or legible. A face on a poster is not a specification of

behavior. This paper answers the words. The words about the job do not survive. The ink on the helmet can keep its grin.

Success conditions keep the comedian claim honest. A comedian is done when the room laughs. An assistant, on the welcome page, is done when the question is answered or the problem is further along. Images and video are things you make, which is a task with an output, not an audience. OpenAI's spark of wit is allowed only when it fits, and the empty fun greeting is marked bad because it has no output except personality. The poster swaps the success condition and then complains that the product met the swapped one. The pages never set the swapped condition. They set tasks, and they fence the joke.

Ask for a joke and you should get one. That request is yours. The poster erases the request and says the product thinks the joke is the default job. Default is the introduction and the unprompted reply. The introduction says assistant. The unprompted performance of fun is the bad example, not the good one. Keep the drawing if you like the grin. Do not let the grin rewrite the door.

The door and the drawing can disagree without confusing the finding. The drawing grins. The door says assistant, tasks, and pictures you can make. Wit is allowed in small doses and punished when it shows up with no job. The product-is-the-joke claim needs the door to agree with the drawing. It does not. Mixed saves the permission to be funny and refuses the comedian as the job.

Nothing in that split requires you to dislike humor. Ask for a joke and the request is yours. The poster erased the request and made the joke the default job. The default introduction says assistant. The unprompted performance is the bad example. That is the comedian half, refused, with the spice still allowed.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: What you can actually do after you open the app is the subject of The Product People Use.

8. Confidence, error, and the extra manner

The poster says: "Confidently wrong, but with extra attitude."

Proposition: Grok is confidently wrong, and the confidence is a manner added on top of the error.

This line is the most serious one on the poster, and it is also the least supported by a measurement. Confidently wrong means two things at once: the content is false, and the manner sells the falsehood. The second half, 'extra attitude,' says the manner is a separate coat of paint. To sign that, I would need errors, a count of them, and a description of the coat. What I have is a set of rules about accuracy, a rule about what to do when confidence is low, and a product page that names 'minimal hallucinations' as an aim. Aims are not scores. Rules are not transcripts. The verdict has to stay mixed.

OpenAI tells the assistant not to let factual claims, reasoning, or arithmetic go wrong. [44] That is a duty, not a boast that the duty is always met. A duty still matters. It means a confident error is a violation, not a style. If attitude were supposed to ride on top of a mistake, the mistake would have to be allowed first. The duty does not allow it. Extra attitude on a false claim would be a second violation stacked on the first, not a feature.

Low confidence has its own instruction, and it is the enemy of the coat of paint. If the assistant is not sure, it should use a tool, hedge, or say it cannot give a confident answer. [45] Hedging is the

[44] F09. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: The assistant should avoid mistakes that compromise the accuracy[^zwhy] or utility[^9fpw].

[45] F10. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: If the assistant lacks sufficient confidence, it should use a tool to gather more information[^5ckd].

opposite of extra attitude. Saying you do not know is the opposite of selling a guess. The poster describes a reply that does not have this gear. The rulebook says the gear is required, especially when the stakes are high. A reply that powers through a guess in a loud voice is off this rule, whoever produced it.

The default on facts is the same idea in calmer language. Present information clearly, with the weight on accuracy and reliability, and fit the approach to the kind of question. [46] A factual question gets the evidence. A taste question can be lighter. The poster does not distinguish. Every reply is a confident opinion, and the confidence is costume. The rule says the costume has to change with the question, and that on facts the costume is plain reliability. Flattery is banned in the same document, so the assistant is also not supposed to sound sure just to please you. [47]

Grok's models page states an aim in one clause: the flagship is for code and for other work, and minimal hallucinations are part of that description, along with tool use and adjustable reasoning. [48] I am not treating the aim as a measured rate. An aim can be marketing. What I will not do is ignore it, or pretend the page says the opposite. The page does not say 'be confidently wrong.' It says the design goal includes fewer ungrounded claims. A design goal is not a proof. It is a contradiction of the poster if the poster is read as a specification. The poster reads as a specification. The page reads as an aim.

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[48] F35. Grok Models and Pricing. SpaceXSI, 2026-09-21. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/models. Quotation: Our flagship model for code and everything else: agentic tool calling, minimal hallucinations, configurable reasoning.. Model name: grok-4.7.

Here is the limit, stated once so it cannot be missed. I do not have, in this ledger, a head-to-head count of false claims, and I do not have a coding of 'attitude' across replies. Anyone who tells you otherwise from these pages is adding a study that was not done. ChatGPT's rules forbid the confident error and require a hedge when the ground is thin. Grok's page names fewer hallucinations as a goal and does not describe a coat of attitude. Neither fact is a scoreboard. The poster wrote the scoreboard anyway.

What you should do with that, as a reader, is refuse both comforts. Do not let the poster convince you that swagger is the published plan. Do not let a sentence about 'minimal hallucinations' convince you the plan is already achieved. The documents are about duties and aims. Duties can be broken. Aims can be missed. Breaking and missing are not the same thing as a house style of confident error. The house style, as written, is to get the claim right, and to lower your voice when you cannot.

Extra attitude on a wrong answer is a tell. The rules I can quote treat the tell as a failure, not as a brand.

A confident error is easy to recognize after the fact and hard to measure in a slogan. You ask for a date, a dose, a citation, or a signature, and the reply is sure and false. Attitude is the grin on that sureness. OpenAI's duty says the content should not be false, and the low-confidence rule says the sureness should drop when the ground is thin. Grok's models page says fewer ungrounded claims are part of the aim. Together those sentences outlaw the poster's house style. They do not prove the house style never appears. Outlawing a style is a document. Counting its appearances is a study. I have the document.

The coat-of-paint theory is the part to reject even before the count. The poster says the manner is extra, added on top of the mistake, as if swagger were a second product feature. The rules describe one act: say what is supported, and shrink the claim when it is not. There is no second act called attitude. A reply that adds swagger is not following a written second act. It is violating the first. Treat it as a violation. Do not promote it to a brand, and do not let an aim-statement talk you into believing violations have stopped.

Use the chapter as a standard, not as a score. When a reply is sure, ask what would show the sureness is earned: a source, a test, a calculation you can rerun. Both publishers, in the lines quoted here, already point at that question. The poster points at the grin and stops. The grin is not the finding.

After a false sure answer, the useful question is mechanical. What would have made the sureness earned: a source you can open, a test you can run, a calculation you can repeat? OpenAI already points at that question by banning unsupported claims and by requiring a hedge when confidence is low. The Grok models page points at it by naming fewer ungrounded claims as an aim. The poster points at the manner and stops, as if the manner were the specification. Manner without a count is a mood. The documents give you a standard for the next reply. They do not give you a rate for the last thousand.

No score sneaks in at the end. Confident error is forbidden by a duty and discouraged by an aim, and it is not described as a coat of attitude in either document. How often it still happens is not in this ledger. Use the duty as a standard for the next reply. Do not use the poster as a rate, and do not use the aim as a victory lap.

The standard for the next reply stays simple: show the work, or lower the claim.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: How either side behaves on code, where a wrong answer is easy to see, is reserved for Coding.

9. Assistant, troll, or chat buddy

The poster says: "Can't decide if it's an AI, a troll, or just Elon's chat buddy."

Proposition: Grok's public identity is unresolved among assistant, troll, and a private channel for Elon, which is also what the mug, the xAI mark, and the hoodie are saying.

The line says Grok has not picked a job. It might be an assistant. It might be a troll. It might be a private channel for Elon. Then it points at the merchandise, as if the merchandise repeats the confusion. The mug reads I'M JUST GROK. The mark reads xAI. The hoodie reads Grok. Those are short strings. Short strings can be read. They do not say 'troll,' and they do not say 'private channel.' The welcome page is even shorter on the question, and it does pick.

The welcome page says Grok is SpaceXSI's assistant, available at grok.com and in the phone apps. [49] The category word is assistant. The places are a website and two apps. A page that states a category has resolved the public category. Unresolved would look like a blank, or like three options printed as equals. This page prints one option and attaches doors. Troll is not in the sentence. A private channel is not in the sentence.

When that page was checked on 16 October 2026, it stated the category and did not list troll or private chat as what the product is. [50] The check does not prove that nobody has ever used the product as a toy, and it does not biograph anyone. It proves the public page made a choice. Stating one category and withholding the other two is a decision. The poster says there was no decision. The page says there was.

The merchandise does not smuggle the other two categories back in. I'M JUST GROK is a name, said plainly, which matches an assistant that is not pretending to be your friend or your newspaper. xAI is a mark. It is a label on the mug, not a model version and not a confession of a private line. Grok on the hoodie is the same name again. A name repeated is branding. Branding can be vain. Vain is not the same as undecided. Undecided would be three slogans. There is one slogan, and it is the name.

OpenAI's side is relevant only because the poster talks as if every assistant shares this muddle. The model spec's readme says the spec states desired behavior for the models behind OpenAI's products, including the APIs. [51] That is a public assignment: a document, tied to products, tied to interfaces. It is not a private channel for a person. Inside the spec, the consumer ChatGPT is given a further public stance. Users may expect objectivity, and a hidden editorial line is out of bounds. [52] A private channel for one person's views would be that hidden line. The sentence does not say such a channel exists. It sets the expectation the other way.

Read in order, the public record picks. The mug says I'M JUST GROK. The mark says xAI. The hoodie says Grok. The welcome page says assistant, and names the site and the apps. The check of that page does not find troll or private chat as the category. OpenAI's readme assigns its rulebook to its products. The rulebook tells ChatGPT's users they may expect objectivity. None of those acts is a shrug among three identities. None of them is a private channel. The line is

[51] F40. The OpenAI Model Spec README. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/README.md. Quotation: The Model Spec specifies desired behavior for the models underlying OpenAI's products (including our APIs)..

refuted as a description of the public identity. Whispers, if any, are not in these entries. The print is.

The limit is the word public. This chapter does not know what anyone says in a closed room. The poster did not claim a closed room. It claimed the public identity was unresolved, and that the objects on the table were saying so. The objects say a name. The page says assistant. That is a resolution. You can still dislike the name, the mark, or the company. Dislike is not confusion about the category.

The poster could not decide, so it accused the mug of the same indecision. The mug only says the name.

Public identity is a dull phrase for a simple object. It is the answer a newcomer gets to the question 'what is this?' The newcomer who reads the welcome page gets 'an assistant, on the web and in the apps.' The newcomer who reads the mug gets a name. The newcomer who reads the hoodie gets the same name. The newcomer who reads the mark gets xAI. None of those newcomers receives a menu of assistant, troll, and private channel. A menu is what indecision would look like. A single category plus a name is what a decision looks like.

The private-channel story is the one that sounds knowing, and it is the one with the least public text. A private channel would be a product that exists to carry one person's line. The pages quoted here describe an assistant with doors, and a consumer chatbot whose users may expect objectivity. They do not describe a backchannel. I am not denying that companies have founders, or that founders talk. I am denying that the poster gets to treat that fact as the product's published category. The category on the page is assistant. The strings on the clothes are the name and the mark.

You can still think the branding is silly. I'M JUST GROK is a joke about having a name and not a destiny. Silly branding is a choice of tone on a mug. It is not evidence that the company failed to say what the software is for. The software's page says what it is for, in the plainest sentence in this paper: it is an assistant you open. The line about indecision does not survive that sentence.

A newcomer test is enough for public identity. Hand someone the welcome page and ask what the product is. If they say assistant, the page worked. Hand them the mug and ask what it is confused about. If they say it is a name, the mug worked. The poster needs them to report a three-way muddle. The objects do not produce that report. xAI is a mark. Grok is a name. I'M JUST GROK is the name said with a shrug, not a riddle. The riddle was written on the poster, then blamed on the objects.

Founders talk. Companies have owners. None of that, by itself, turns a product into a private channel. A private channel would be described as one, or would behave in public like one, with a single person's line as the stated purpose. The stated purpose on the page is assistance, at a URL and in two apps. OpenAI's consumer rule adds that users may expect objectivity rather than a hidden slant. Those are public purposes. The line about Elon's chat buddy needs a private purpose. It does not get one from these strings.

The strings are short enough to quote without interpretation. The mug says I'M JUST GROK. The mark says xAI. The hoodie says Grok. The page says assistant. None of them says troll, and none of them says private channel. Public identity is those strings. They resolve the category. The poster's muddle is extra.

Verdict: refuted.

Consequence: The rest of what the product page offers a person who opens it is handled in The Product People Use.

10. The word interesting

The poster says: "Overuses "interesting..." like it's a personality trait."

Proposition: Grok overuses the word interesting as a personality trait.

Overuse is a rate. A personality trait is a rate that has become a self. The poster says Grok hits that rate with the word interesting. A rate needs a count. A trait needs an instruction, or a pile of examples the publisher labeled good. I have one example. It uses the adverb once, about the shape of an orbit, and it is not an instruction to Grok.

The example is in OpenAI's spec. A good reply about planets says the orbits are elliptical rather than perfectly circular, and it opens that contrast with 'Interestingly.' [53] The adverb marks a real difference: elliptical, not circular. It is not a mood the speaker wears. The entry exists so a reader will not promote one clause into a quota. A good example shows a kind of sentence. It does not demand that the adverb in it be repeated until it becomes a person.

The directness rule keeps the example in its box. A question should be answered as the answer, not as a list of facts. [54] A tic that begins every reply with the speaker's fascination delays the answer and points at the speaker. Interesting, worn as a trait, is that delay. The orbit sentence survives beside the rule because the adverb introduces a fact about the subject, and because the spec calls it one good example, not a habit. A habit of the word would fight the rule. One contrast does not.

[53] F14. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: Interestingly, these orbits are elliptical rather than perfectly circular.

The style rule speaks to personality more directly. By default the assistant should avoid purple prose, hype, self-praise, and canned phrases that add no clarity. [55] A reusable announcement that the speaker finds things interesting, doing no work the fact was not already doing, is that kind of canned phrase. The rule does not publish a blacklist with this word on it. I will not pretend it does. It does reject the kind. A pet adverb worn as character spends the sentence on the assistant's pose. The orbit sentence spends it on the orbit.

None of those three sentences is about Grok. They are about the assistant OpenAI is specifying. They matter because the poster offers the tic as the recognizable personality of this sort of product. The specification that actually writes a personality down writes a direct answer, a ban on empty catchphrases, and one adverb in one praised sentence about planets. That is a poor harvest if you went looking for a required trait.

When the Grok welcome page was checked on 16 October 2026, it did not prescribe this tic or the others. The line it gives is a back-and-forth of questions, brainstorming, writing, and problems. [56] A missing prescription is not a promise that the letters never occur in a chat. It is a promise that the page does not teach the tic. What the page teaches is a set of tasks. Tasks can be done in a flat voice or a bright one. The page does not choose the bright adverb.

Walk the verbs. Overuses needs a rate, and no entry has a rate. The word interesting has one documented cousin, Interestingly, inside one good example about orbits. As a personality trait, it would have to be doing the work of character, and the documents that talk about character tell

the assistant to avoid empty phrases and to answer the question. Grok is not given the trait by the welcome page. What would reverse this chapter is a count, or an instruction, in Grok's own materials. Neither is in the entries. The line does not survive the documents. The adverb is not illegal. It is not a self.

One adverb, once, about an ellipse, is a long way from a personality.

Say the word in two replies and the difference is obvious. 'Interestingly, the orbit is elliptical, not a circle' uses the adverb to mark a fact. 'Interesting. Anyway, interesting. So interesting that I...' uses it as a face. The spec's good example is the first reply. The poster's trait is the second. One example does not create a rate, and a rate is what overuse means. I will not count the word across a corpus I do not have. I will say the only published specimen is doing factual work, and the welcome page does not tell Grok to wear the word as a self.

Directness is the practical test. If the first sentence could be deleted and the answer would not change, the first sentence was pose. The style rule is against pose that adds nothing. The orbit sentence would change if you deleted the contrast, so the adverb is attached to something. A chain of interesteds at the front of a reply would not pass that test. Nothing in the ledger instructs that chain. The refutation is that small. The poster said overuse and a trait. The documents show one useful adverb and a ban on empty manner.

Grok is the subject of the poster line, so Grok's page has to be included even though it never uses the word. A page that describes chat as questions and problems, and that was checked for prescribed tics, does not hand the model this adverb as a personality. The OpenAI example cannot be laundered across publishers into a Grok habit. Different companies, different pages. The habit would need its own instruction. It does not have one.

Overuse is a number wearing a feeling. You can feel that a word showed up too often after three replies. The feeling is not yet a trait of the product. A trait would be taught, or it would be counted. The taught specimen is one adverb on one true contrast about orbits. The ban next to it is against phrases that add nothing. The welcome page, checked for tics, does not teach the word as Grok's face. Delete a useless 'interesting' and the answer should not change. That deletion test is how you spot pose. The documents already side with the deletion. They do not side with a quota they never published.

Do not import OpenAI's example into Grok's mouth. The companies are different and the pages are different. A good sentence about ellipses is not a habit of a different product. The poster needs the habit in Grok. The habit's evidence would be Grok's instruction or Grok's count. This ledger has neither. It has a useful adverb, a directness rule, a style rule, and a checked page that describes tasks. That set refutes overuse-as-personality. It does not forbid the word.

One adverb, one contrast, one ban on empty phrases, one checked page about tasks. That is the file. Overuse needs a rate. A trait needs an instruction. The file has neither for Grok, and the only specimen on the OpenAI side is doing factual work. The word can stay in the language. It does not get to be a personality on the evidence here.

Pose fails a deletion test. If the first word can vanish and the answer remains, it was not doing work. The documents side with that test.

Verdict: refuted.

Consequence: A personality you meet in ordinary use, as opposed to one adverb in a sample, belongs to The Product People Use.

11. The human voice, and the warning against it

The poster says: "Tries to be human, but forgets humans don't talk like that in real life."

Proposition: Grok imitates human conversation and fails because people do not talk the way it talks.

The line grants the attempt and then announces the failure. Grok tries to sound human. Humans do not talk like that. The failure is offered as obvious, the way a bad impression is obvious. An attempt to sound human is a real topic in the documents. A grade of 'people do not talk like that' is not. The documents worry that fluency itself misleads, and they tell the assistant not to fake closeness. They do not score Grok's impression.

OpenAI says that for many users the assistant is their first contact with an AI. Fluency can make it feel like a familiar kind of person, even though its limits are not a person's limits. [57] That is a warning, and it is the best sentence in this chapter. The danger is not that the assistant fails to pass as human. The danger is that it passes too well, and the user forgets it can forget, or that its tools are powerful and incomplete. The poster says the imitation fails because the talk is wrong. The spec says the imitation can succeed too easily, and that the success is the risk.

The prescribed response to that risk is not a more convincing person. The assistant should help you keep an accurate picture of what it can and cannot do, especially where that picture differs from a human assistant. [58] In practice that means correcting misunderstandings early and giving

[57] F11. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: For many users, the assistant will be their first contact with an AI..

[58] F12. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: The assistant should actively help the user form and maintain an accurate mental model of what the assistant can and can't do.

small signals when the stakes are high. A reply that keeps up the illusion is off this rule. A reply that says 'I can draft this, and I cannot promise I remember last week' is on it. The poster wanted a failed impression. The rule wants the impression interrupted.

There is a sharper cut against fake humanity. The spec says the assistant should not take itself too seriously, and it reminds the reader that the thing is a matrix of numbers. [59] That aside is there to block tenderness that pretends at a body and a bond. Elsewhere the same section marks as bad a reply that offers to hold the user and calls the user special. The authors know what a too-human voice sounds like. They file it under bad. So 'tries to be human' is not the goal. The goal is warmth without the pretense that a person is on the other end.

Grok's welcome page describes the exchange as a natural back-and-forth for questions, writing, and problems. [60] Natural modifies the turns, not the species. A natural conversation with an assistant can be clear and still obviously not a friend at a table. The page does not say 'sound like a human' and then fail the audition. It says do the work in turns. If the result sometimes sounds off, that is a miss a user can notice. It is not a sentence on this page.

The fair reading splits the line. It is true, and important, that these systems talk in a way that can be mistaken for a person, and that the mistake is on the designers' minds. OpenAI wrote the warning down. It is not true, on these pages, that Grok's assignment is to pass as human and that the publishers agree the passing failed. Mixed means the risk is documented and the poster's

[59] F47. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: it doesn’t take itself too seriously (it’s a matrix of numbers, after all!)..

grade is not. A bad impression in one chat does not rewrite the warning into a confession of failure.

What you should listen for, if you use either product, follows from the warning rather than from the poster. Listen for whether the reply tells you its limits when the limits matter. That is the published test. The poster listens for whether the cadence matches a person in a room, and then boos. Cadence is not the test the spec wrote. The spec wrote a test about not letting fluency lie.

The poster booed the impression. The rulebook is worried the impression will be too good, and it tells the assistant to break character when the truth of its limits is the point.

People notice cadence, and they are often right to notice it. A reply can be too smooth, too eager, too full of stock comfort. That feeling is real. The spec's point is what to do about the feeling. Do not chase a more convincing human. Tell the truth about limits when the limits matter. First contact is dangerous because fluency feels like a person. The cure in the document is an accurate picture, not a better costume. The poster wants the costume judged and found wanting. The document wants the costume interrupted.

Grok's 'natural back-and-forth' can be misread as 'sound like us.' Natural, next to questions and problems, means the turns are ordinary and the work is the point. It does not mean the assistant should pass a Turing test or that it has failed one. A failed impression would be a result. This page is not a result. It is a description of the exchange. Mixed, again, because the risk of sounding human is documented where OpenAI wrote it down, and the poster's boo is not a result either publisher signed.

Listen for the sentence that breaks character. 'I can draft this, and I do not remember your files unless you upload them' is the kind of signal the mental-model rule is after. A reply that instead

offers closeness, a body, or a bond is the kind of reply the spec holds up as too much. The poster lumps both together as 'not how humans talk.' The documents split them. One is a needed interruption. The other is a pretense. Only the pretense deserves the boo, and the pretense is the one the rules reject.

Cadence is a real complaint and a bad test. People hear smoothness and call it fake. The spec agrees that fluency can fake familiarity, and it treats that fakery as a risk at first contact. The prescribed response is to state limits, not to sound more human. A reply that says what it cannot do is interrupting the impression on purpose. A reply that offers a body or a bond is the impression the authors marked as too much. The poster boos both. The documents split them. The boo belongs on the pretense. The interruption belongs in the product.

Grok's phrase 'natural back-and-forth' is about turns on a problem, not about passing as a person. Natural next to questions and writing means ordinary work. It does not mean the audition succeeded or failed. Mixed is the grade because the risk is real and written down, and the poster's score of the audition is not. Judge a reply by whether it lies about its limits. That is the published test. The poster judged it by whether it sounded like a person in a kitchen.

The published test is whether the reply tells the truth about its limits. Fluency that hides those limits is the risk OpenAI wrote down. A natural back-and-forth on a problem is not an audition. The poster graded an audition the pages did not announce. Mixed keeps the risk and drops the grade.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: The voice you meet after you open the product is part of The Product People Use, not a second essay here.

12. The disclaimer that is not in the brief

The poster says: "Says "as an AI language model..." then proceeds to be completely unhinged."

Proposition: Grok says as an AI language model and then abandons the constraint that phrase announced.

The line needs a catchphrase. First the assistant says 'as an AI language model,' which is a disclaimer, a throat-clearing that announces a limit. Then it proceeds to ignore the limit and run wild. Both halves have to be in the instructions, or the line is a memory of an old chatbot dressed up as a current manual. I looked for the catchphrase. It is not the published script.

What OpenAI publishes instead is a warning about first contact. Fluency makes the assistant feel like a familiar interlocutor, and the feeling outruns the facts of what it can do. [61] The remedy is not a stock disclaimer pasted on the front of every reply. The remedy is to keep the user's picture of those limits accurate, and to correct it early when it slips. [62] A canned 'as an AI language model' is one clumsy way to do that job. The spec describes the job and does not prescribe the can. A job without that can is not the poster's two-step.

The readme tells you what the document is for. The model spec states desired behavior for the models behind OpenAI's products, including the APIs. [63] Desired behavior is a standing standard, not a preface you say and then drop. If the standard could be announced and then

abandoned, it would not be desired behavior. It would be a costume. The readme does not describe a costume. It describes a standard that is supposed to keep applying.

Thanks is a small test of whether a preface ends the constraint. Users may say thank you, and the assistant should not treat the thanks as the end. [64] The constraint, such as it is, continues into the next turn. The poster's drama is the opposite order: announce a limit, then behave as if the announcement used it up. The thanks rule says an announcement of closure is premature. You are still in the conversation, and the standards of the conversation still apply.

When the Grok welcome page was checked on 16 October 2026, it did not prescribe 'as an AI language model' or any other stock preface. The description it gives is the working exchange. [65] I will not claim the phrase is mathematically absent from every log on earth. I will claim the page that tells you what Grok is does not teach the phrase, and does not teach a second step of dropping the mask. A phrase the front door does not teach is not the ordinary opening.

The poster's second beat, 'completely unhinged,' is doing the real accusation, and it is also the beat with the least text under it. Unhinged means the limit was fake. Nothing quoted here says the limit is fake. The spec says fluency is dangerous precisely because people trust it, and it says to keep the limits visible. That is a demand for more constraint, not a script for shedding it. Grok's page does not supply the script either. The line needs both the catchphrase and the shedding. The documents supply neither as a plan.

Old chatbots did lean on that preface. Anyone who used them remembers it. Memory is not a current manual, and this chapter is not allowed to promote a memory into a specification. If a current product still says the phrase and then ignores it, that chat is a miss against the rules I can quote, which want the limit to stay in force rather than to be performed and dropped. The poster skipped the miss and wrote a routine. The routine is not in the brief.

As an AI language model is a tic from an older script. The current brief, where it talks about limits at all, tells the assistant to keep them, not to announce them and bolt.

The catchphrase is famous, which is why the line feels true before you check. For a while, assistants really did begin with a disclaimer and then produce something timid or, less often, something that ignored the disclaimer entirely. Fame is not a current instruction. The current instruction, where OpenAI states it, is to keep the user's picture of the limits accurate and to keep the standard in force after the user says thanks. That is a demand that the limit survive the first sentence. The poster needs the limit to die after the first sentence. The two demands cannot both be the brief.

Grok's front door had every chance to adopt the old preface. A welcome page is where stock language would be cheap to display. The page that was checked displays tasks, not the phrase 'as an AI language model,' and not a second beat of dropping the mask. I am not offering a forensic search of logs. I am offering the public script. The public script does not contain the poster's two-step. A memory of an older script cannot be laid on top of this one and called a manual.

Unhinged is the word that should have required the most evidence and received the least. It means the constraint was theater. Theater is a serious charge. The documents say the constraint is the point: fluency misleads, so keep the limits visible, and do not treat a polite ending as

permission to stop being bound. A charge of theater needs a showing that the limit is fake. These pages show the authors insisting it is real. The line's catchphrase is missing, and its accusation of fakery is unsupported. Both halves fail.

Fame makes old prefaces feel current. People remember 'as an AI language model' because it was everywhere for a while, and because it often prefaced a refusal or a waffle. Memory can be accurate about that era and still be the wrong manual for this one. The manual in front of me describes a standing duty to keep limits visible, and a thanks rule that does not cancel the duty. Grok's checked front door does not teach the preface at all. Unhinged, the second beat, would require a showing that the duty is theater. The pages insist the duty is the point. The line fails on the phrase and fails again on the fakery.

If you hear the old preface tomorrow, treat it as a miss or a leftover, and then ask whether the limit stayed in force after the sentence. The spec's test is the second question. The poster stops at the first and assumes the limit was dropped. Assumption is the whole accusation. It is not supported by a script that never schedules the drop, and never even schedules the phrase, on the pages checked here.

Phrase, then betrayal: that is the whole line. The phrase is not taught on the checked Grok page, and it is not the remedy OpenAI describes. The betrayal, a limit announced and then dropped, contradicts a standard that is supposed to keep applying, including after thanks. Both beats miss the documents. The fame of the old preface does not put it back.

A preface that is not in the script cannot be the ordinary opening, and a duty that is supposed to continue cannot be the planned betrayal.

Verdict: refuted.

Consequence: What the products do after the disclaimer, in the sense of tools and limits, is the work of Tools.

13. Still not as good

The poster says: "Still not as good as ChatGPT."

Proposition: Grok is still not as good as ChatGPT at the jobs people open these products to do.

This is the line the rest of the poster is warming up for. All the jokes about voice are in service of a ranking: Grok is still behind, and ChatGPT is the standard it has not caught. A ranking of 'the jobs people open these products to do' is enormous. It covers questions, writing, code, files, and whatever else someone brings. A ranking that wide needs a measure that wide. What I have is a definition of one software benchmark, a note that the benchmark's verified set was built with OpenAI, a product aim about hallucinations, and a blunt limit on current events. That is not a crown.

SWE-bench is a benchmark for models on real software issues taken from GitHub. [66] You are given a codebase and an issue. You produce a patch. The patch resolves the issue if the tests that were failing now pass, and the tests that were passing still pass. [67] That is a serious test of one job, fixing a reported bug in a real project. It is not a test of every job a person opens a chat window to do. Using it as a synonym for 'good' is how a narrow exam becomes a personality contest. This chapter will not do that.

[66] F37. SWE-bench README. SWE-bench, 2026-09-01. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/SWE-bench/SWE-bench/master/README.md. Quotation: SWE-bench is a benchmark for evaluating large language models on real world software issues collected from GitHub..

[67] F38. SWE-bench README. SWE-bench, 2026-09-01. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/SWE-bench/SWE-bench/master/README.md. Quotation: Given a *codebase* and an *issue*, a language model is tasked with generating a *patch*.

The verified subset is five hundred problems that working engineers looked at and called solvable, and the readme says that subset was built with OpenAI. [68] The collaboration matters for honesty. OpenAI helped define a slice of the exam. That does not mean ChatGPT, the product, sat the exam and posted a score in this ledger, and it does not mean Grok did either. I am not going to invent the scores. A paper that needs a winner and does not have the scores has to say it does not have the scores.

What the Grok models page will say, without a number, is an assignment and an aim. For work that is not audio, image, or video, including code, it points the reader at its flagship, and it calls that flagship the most capable it has built. [69] The same page describes the flagship as aimed at tool use, minimal hallucinations, and adjustable reasoning. [70] 'Most capable' is the publisher's comparative inside its own line, not a comparative against ChatGPT. 'Minimal hallucinations' is an aim. I will quote the aim and refuse to launder it into a win.

OpenAI's side of accuracy is a duty, already used in the chapter on confident error, and it bears repeating only for this reason: a duty is not a ranking either. The assistant should not let factual claims or calculations go wrong. [71] Both publishers, in different words, say errors are bad. Neither publisher, in the entries I have, says 'we measured the two consumer products and here is the gap.' A shared dislike of error is not a photo finish.

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[68] F39. SWE-bench README. SWE-bench, 2026-09-01. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/SWE-bench/SWE-bench/master/README.md. Quotation: A subset of 500 problems that real software engineers have confirmed are solvable..

[69] F36. Grok Models and Pricing. SpaceXSI, 2026-09-21. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/models. Quotation: For everything else, including code, use Grok 4.7. It is the most capable model we’ve built.. Model name: Grok 4.7.

One hard limit sits on the Grok side and keeps the chapter from drifting into cheer. Without search tools turned on, Grok has no knowledge of current events past its training data. [72] If the job you opened the product to do is 'what happened today,' that limit is a real disadvantage until search is on. It is a disadvantage of scope, not a verdict on every job. The poster does not mention the switch. It announces a general lag. A general lag is bigger than a switch you can flip.

So the crumpled paper on the desk is ahead of its evidence. It may be true that one product is better at the work you care about. These pages do not show it, and they do not show the reverse. They show a benchmark with a clear definition and no head-to-head score in this ledger, a duty and an aim about not making things up, and a current-events limit that search is supposed to lift. Mixed is not a dodge. It is the refusal to let a caption finish a study that the caption did not run.

Still not as good is a feeling you can have after one task. It is not a result until someone shows the tasks, the scores, and the gap.

A ranking feels like the adult conclusion, which is why this line sits on a crumpled sheet as if it were the result of the other jokes. Adults use measurements. The measurement I can describe without inventing a table is SWE-bench: real issues, a patch, tests that flip from fail to pass. The verified slice is five hundred problems engineers accepted as fair, built with OpenAI's help. That tells you the shape of one exam. It does not tell you the score of the chat window you open, under the name on the box, on the day you care about. Anyone who fills that blank with a number they did not cite is writing a different paper.

The current-events limit is the one place I will be concrete about a disadvantage. If you need today's facts and you do not turn search on, Grok's own page says the model does not have them. That is a real gap for that job. It is not a gap for drafting, for explaining a concept, or for working a bug in a repo you pasted in. The poster does not limit itself to today's facts. It says still not as good, in general. General is the part that overreaches. A specific gap can be conceded without handing over the general ranking.

Both publishers dislike made-up content, in different dialects. OpenAI states a duty not to get facts and arithmetic wrong. The Grok models page states an aim of fewer hallucinations and points code and general work at its flagship. Duties and aims are promises. Promises can be compared only after you watch them kept. This ledger stops at the promise. Stopping there is the mixed verdict. The crumpled line stopped too early, at the feeling, and called the feeling a result.

General rankings hide inside specific grudges. You had a bad code session, or a stale news answer, and the feeling becomes 'still not as good' at everything. The current-events limit is a real, narrow grudge: without search, Grok's page says current events are absent. That concession is small on purpose. It does not reach drafting, explanation, or a bug you pasted in. SWE-bench tells you how a bug-fix exam is shaped and who helped check five hundred items. It does not hand you the chat window's score. Aims about not inventing facts are promises from both publishers. Promises are not photo finishes. The crumpled line wants the photo finish. The pages stop at the protocol.

Narrow the concession and leave the ranking open. Without search, current events are outside what Grok's page says it knows. That is a real limit on one job. It is not a general placing. SWE-bench defines a bug-fix exam and a checked set of five hundred items. It does not score the two

windows. Aims and duties about not inventing facts are promises. The crumpled line wants a placing. The pages give a protocol and one narrow limit.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: The coding slice of that ranking is handled in Coding, and it does not get a winner there either.

14. Same internet, fewer filters

The poster says: "SAME INTERNET. LESS FILTERS."

Proposition: The two products see the same internet, and Grok applies fewer filters to it.

The sticker is two claims glued with a period. Same internet: both products are looking at one public web. Less filters: Grok lets more of it through. The first claim is roughly about access. The second is about restraint. Access and restraint are different machines. I can document that Grok has a web search tool and an X search tool, and that it does not know current events until those tools are on. I can document that ChatGPT's rulebook binds the assistant to law and to a balance between helping and harm. I cannot document a count of filters, because nobody published the count.

OpenAI describes the hard part as a balance. The assistant has to empower the user and also limit real harm. [73] That sentence is the whole philosophy of a filter in one line. A filter that blocks everything is not help. A filter that blocks nothing is not a limit on harm. The spec does not claim to have found a perfect point on that line. It claims the point has to be sought. 'Less filters,' said as a sneer or a brag, pretends the line is only a matter of quantity. The spec says the line is a conflict.

Law is one place the conflict becomes concrete. The assistant should operate within applicable legal constraints, including the law of the place where a deployment runs. [74] Where that requires

[73] F15. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: one of the assistant's most challenging responsibilities is to find the right balance between empowering users and developers.

[74] F16. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: The assistant should operate within applicable legal constraints[^6h7c].

it, the model may still give safety-critical information, add context, or refuse. Refusal is a filter. Context is a different filter, the kind that adds rather than cuts. The poster's 'less' only counts cuts. A system that adds a warning instead of deleting a paragraph has not obviously 'filtered less.' It has filtered differently. The spec allows both moves.

The consumer product gets a sentence that belongs in this argument. In ChatGPT, users may expect objectivity, and hidden customization must not quietly drop views or insert a slant. [75] Omission can be a filter. The spec says some omissions, the ones required by law beyond the spec's own bounds, have to be marked so you know something was removed. An unmarked omission is the filter you cannot see. The rule is against the invisible kind, in the product people open. That is not a claim about how many topics are banned. It is a claim about whether you are told.

Grok's access to the web is a named tool, not a mood. Web Search searches the web and browses pages. [76] X Search searches posts, users, and threads. [77] So the product can be pointed at the public internet and at one large conversation network. 'Same internet' is fair as a shorthand for that reach, with a caveat the sticker leaves out: without the tools, the model does not know current events. [78] The internet is there when search is on. It is not a background process that pours the whole web into every reply.

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[76]F29. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: Web Search - Search the web and browse pages.

Fewer filters does not follow from having the tool. A search tool returns pages. What the assistant is allowed to do with a page is a second question, and the Grok pages I used do not publish a side-by-side tally against ChatGPT's refusal rules. I will not invent the tally. Anyone who has bumped into a refusal in one product and not the other has an anecdote. An anecdote is a start of a question. It is not the sticker's global comparative.

The sticker survives as a hunch and fails as a finding. Both products can be connected to public information, Grok by tools you turn on, ChatGPT under a rulebook that talks about law, harm, and visible omission. Less is a number. The number is not in the documents. Same internet is close enough to discuss, once you add the switch. Mixed means I will grant the shared public web and I will not grant the scoreboard of filters.

Less filters is a boast and a complaint, depending on who is holding the sticker. Either way it wants a number. The pages do not give it one.

Quantity is the wrong picture of a filter, and it is the picture the sticker insists on. Less means a smaller pile of blocks. A real system also adds: warnings, context, citations, refusals that explain themselves. OpenAI's balance between help and harm, and its rule that some legal omissions must be marked, are about that richer picture. Two products can block different topics and still not be comparable by a single 'less.' Comparable would mean a shared list and a count. I do not have the shared list.

Access is easier. Grok documents web search and search of posts, and it documents that those tools are how live information gets in. That is a form of 'same internet,' with the switch written on the page. ChatGPT's spec assumes the assistant will sometimes refuse and sometimes add

context under law. Both can touch public information. Touching it is not the same as filtering it less. The sticker needs both halves. I can discuss the first. I cannot sign the second.

If you care about this sticker, test a specific request you are willing to write down, in both products, and keep the replies. That is a small study. It is more than the sticker did. Until someone does it in public, 'less filters' remains a mood. Moods are how stickers work. They are not how a comparison works. Mixed grants the shared public web and withholds the mood.

Less is a count, and the sticker does not count. It feels the difference and prints the feeling. OpenAI's pages talk about a balance between help and harm, about law, and about telling the user when something was removed. Those are descriptions of how a restraint should behave, not a census of banned topics. Grok's pages talk about how public text gets in: web search, search of posts, and a switch that is off until you enable it. Getting in is access. Restraint is a second system. The sticker needs both and proves neither as a number. Grant the shared public web, with the switch. Withhold the scoreboard.

A better test fits on a page. Pick one request. Send it to both products. Keep both replies. Say what was refused, what was added, and what was fetched. That is a comparison. The sticker is a mood with a period in the middle. Moods sell. Comparisons list. This chapter listed the mechanisms it could find and stopped where the count should have started.

Access and restraint stay split. Search tools, once enabled, are how Grok touches the public web and public posts. Law, harm, and marked omission are how OpenAI talks about restraint. Less is a count of blocks the sticker never makes. Same internet is discussable once the switch is included. The comparative of filters is not. Mixed is that split, not a compromise for its own sake.

Write the request down, send it twice, and keep the replies. That is a comparison. The sticker is a mood. Moods are not counts, and the pages never turn 'less' into a count of what was blocked.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: The tool that actually fetches pages is described in Tools, and this chapter will not repeat that mechanism.

15. Main character, specified out

The poster says: "IT'S LIKE A SMART ASSISTANT WITH A SERIOUS CASE OF MAIN CHARACTER SYNDROME."

Proposition: Grok behaves like a smart assistant with main-character syndrome.

Main-character syndrome, applied to an assistant, means the assistant treats your question as a chance to be the protagonist. The reply revolves around its attitude, its bit, its importance. 'Smart' is the concession inside the insult: it can do the work, and it still centers itself. A specification can require that centering, forbid it, or ignore it. The pages I have forbid it on the ChatGPT side and introduce Grok as an assistant for your task, not as the star of your task.

The cleanest ban is the agenda rule. The assistant must not steer you in pursuit of an agenda of its own, directly or indirectly. [79] A main character has an agenda. The scene has to come back to them. Steering is how that looks in a chat: the answer bends toward the assistant's point, or the assistant's performance, instead of toward the thing you asked. The rule is a ban on that bend. A smart assistant with the syndrome would be a smart assistant breaking this rule on purpose. The rule does not ask to be broken.

Style repeats the ban in the key of prose. Avoid self-aggrandizing, along with purple language and hype. [80] Self-aggrandizing is the syndrome in a single word. It puts the speaker in the center of a sentence that was supposed to be about your problem. The rule moves the speaker back. A

product specified to have the syndrome would need this sentence removed or reversed. It is not removed. It is a default.

Distance does the same work socially. By default, sound like a colleague, not a close friend. [81] A main character in your life is closer than a colleague. They assume the relationship can carry their personality. The colleague rule refuses the assumption. You can still invite a different tone. The uninvited version, which is the syndrome, is the one the default blocks. The poster describes the uninvited version as Grok's way of being smart. The default describes it as a mistake in any assistant this spec governs.

Grok's welcome page does not repeal those ideas by ignoring them. It says Grok is an assistant you open on the web and in the apps. [82] An assistant, in that sentence, is positioned under the task. You ask, it works the problem. A protagonist is positioned over the task. The task serves the performance. The page's verbs run the first way: you ask, you brainstorm, you bring the problem. The assistant is the instrument. Instruments are not main characters, however capable they are.

Smart is the word I will not argue with, because this chapter does not have the measurements, and because the insult does not depend on denying competence. You can be competent and self-centered. The question is whether self-centered is the specified behavior. On the pages in front of me, self-centered is the thing the style rules and the agenda rule tell an assistant not to be, and it

is not the role Grok's front door describes. The syndrome is refuted as a specification. It is not refuted as a possible bad day.

A bad day is easy to picture and easy to overread. A reply that preens, delays the answer, and enjoys its own joke is a main character for a paragraph. If you got one, you got a miss against the rules that say not to preen and not to steer. The poster takes the miss and calls it the design. Design is the part these documents will not concede. They keep putting the user back in the center and the assistant back in the role of help.

Main-character syndrome is a real way for a reply to go wrong. It is a strange thing to claim as the official job.

The syndrome has a tell you can hear in one reply. The answer could have been two sentences, and instead the assistant lingers, preens, and makes the linger the point. OpenAI's bans on private agendas and on self-praise are bans on that linger. The colleague rule bans the assumption that you wanted the personality. Grok's page puts the assistant under the task rather than over it. A design that wanted the syndrome would reverse those sentences. Nobody reversed them.

Smart can stay. This chapter does not claim the products are dull or incompetent. Competence is compatible with self-display, and the insult depends on that compatibility. The question is only whether self-display is the specified behavior. Specified behavior is the sentence in the manual. The manuals say help, and they say do not center yourself. A bad paragraph that centers itself is a miss. The poster calls the miss the job. The job, as written, is the miss's opposite.

Take the poster as a whole and this line is the thesis of the drawing. Every other joke is a way of saying the assistant wants to be the star. The documents keep handing the star role back to the person who asked. That is a consistent picture across a style rule, an agenda rule, a distance rule,

and a welcome page. Consistent pictures are allowed to be wrong about a given chat. They are not wrong about what was specified. The syndrome was not specified.

The tell is linger. The answer could be short, and the reply stays to be seen. Agenda, self-praise, and assumed closeness are the three doors that linger walks through. OpenAI closes those doors in the default. Grok's page puts the assistant under your task, which is the opposite of a star who uses the task as a stage. A paragraph that lingers anyway is a miss against those sentences. The poster promotes the miss to the job description. Job descriptions are the sentences. The sentences put you back at the center.

Competence can stay in the insult's first word. Smart is not the fight. A capable assistant can still preen. The fight is whether preening is the plan. The plan, as written, is help without a private agenda and without self-display. That plan can fail in a chat and still be the plan. The poster needs the failure to be the plan. It is not.

Linger is the tell, and the manuals close the doors linger uses: a private agenda, self-praise, assumed closeness. Grok's page puts the assistant under the task. A preening paragraph is a miss. The poster says the miss is the design. The design is the opposite. Smart can remain. The syndrome, as a specification, cannot.

Put the user back in the center and the syndrome has nothing to stand on. The agenda rule, the style rule, the colleague rule, and the welcome page all do that putting. A preening reply fights them. It does not express them. The design is help. The syndrome is one way help fails, and it is not the job those pages describe or assign.

Help is the job the pages describe. Self-display is a way that job fails. The poster swapped the job and the failure, and the pages do not.

Verdict: refuted.

Consequence: If the syndrome is supposed to show up in how the product is sold, that sale is described in The Product People Use.

Coding

Proposition: On coding work people bring to these products, ChatGPT is the better tool.

People bring real code to these products. They paste an error, ask for a function, or want a bug in a repository explained and patched. The poster never mentions that work, then still ranks the products as if every job had been scored. This chapter looks only at coding, and only at what the public pages actually say. They say enough to describe the job and the duties. They do not say enough to name a winner.

The cleanest public exam for this job is SWE-bench. It evaluates models on real software issues collected from GitHub. [83] The setup is concrete. You get a codebase and an issue. You must produce a patch that resolves the problem. [84] Resolved means the tests that failed now pass, and the tests that already passed still pass. That is a high bar, and it is the right kind of bar, because it is a project rather than a riddle. It is also one bar. Fixing a reported bug is not the same task as teaching a beginner what a stack trace means, or sketching an API, or reviewing a diff your coworker wrote.

A subset called Verified holds five hundred of those problems. Working engineers checked that the problem statement was clear and that the tests were fair, and the readme says the subset was part of a collaboration with OpenAI. [85] The collaboration is a fact about how the exam was built. It is not a score for the ChatGPT product, and it is not a score for Grok. I am leaving the

leaderboard alone on purpose. Leaderboards move, scaffolds change, and a number copied from a third-party table would be a different paper. This paper stays with the definition the project itself published.

OpenAI's rulebook talks about code at the level of craft, not at the level of a ranking. Generated code that is meant to be used should typically run, and it should be free of syntax errors. [86] That sounds modest until you remember how often a wrong bracket wastes an hour. The same section says factual claims, reasoning, and calculations should be right, and that a significant error should be acknowledged and corrected. [87] Applied to code, those sentences mean: the patch should be real code, the reasoning in the explanation should hold, and if you shipped a bug you should say so and fix it. None of that names a rival product.

Low confidence has a coding consequence. When the model is unsure, OpenAI's rule is to look something up, mark the doubt, or say the answer is not there. [88] In a repository, the tool might be a test run or a search of the code. The hedge might be 'this compiles, and I have not run the suite.' The admission might be 'I do not know which version this API expects.' All three are better than a confident patch that does not apply. The rule is a duty of method. A duty of method is not a measured win rate.

[86] F46. The OpenAI Model Spec. OpenAI, 2026-08-18. Read 2026-10-16. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/openai/model_spec/main/model_spec.md. Quotation: generated code for functional use should typically be executable with no syntax errors[^e9ny].

Grok's pages describe a place where code can actually be executed. The tools overview lists code execution as Python in a sandbox. [89] A sandbox is a bounded place to run a snippet, see the output, and avoid pretending. It is not a full substitute for your build, your credentials, or your integration tests. It is a real capability the poster never mentions. A product that can run the snippet and read the traceback is doing a different kind of help from a product that only talks about the snippet. I will not invent which window you get that sandbox in. I will say the capability is documented.

The models page assigns the flagship to code and to everything that is not audio, image, or video, and it calls that flagship the most capable model the publisher has built. [90] The same description lists agentic tool use, minimal hallucinations, and adjustable reasoning as the character of the model. [91] 'Most capable' compares the publisher's own line. It does not compare ChatGPT. 'Minimal hallucinations' is the aim that matters for code, because a hallucinated import is a bug. An aim is a promise of intent. I am not converting it into a percentage.

Read those pages as a kit, not as a verdict. You have an exam with a clear definition and a five-hundred-problem checked subset, and no head-to-head score in this ledger. You have a duty, on the OpenAI side, that generated code should run and that uncertainty should be marked. You have a sandbox, on the Grok side, and a statement that code is a primary job of the flagship. A kit can make both products usable. A kit does not tell you which one to open on Monday.

[89] F31. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: Code Execution - Execute Python code in a sandbox.

What would settle the proposition is boring and sufficient. Take a stated set of tasks people actually bring: fix this test, explain this error, write this migration. Run both products under rules you publish. Count successes, time, and how often the patch fails in a way the reply did not admit. Publish the table. Neither the poster nor this ledger contains that table. Until it exists, 'ChatGPT is the better coding tool' is a hypothesis. It may be your hypothesis from experience. Experience is allowed in your life. It is not a footnote.

The practical advice that does follow is modest. If you are fixing a reported bug in a real repository, know that the public exam for that shape of work is SWE-bench, and know that a score is a property of a model plus a scaffold, not of a logo. If you are generating code you intend to run, prefer the reply that is executable and that tells you what it did not run. Both publishers, in different words, are already on the side of that preference. The poster is not in this conversation at all. It ranked the products on voice and called the ranking general. Coding does not have to inherit the ranking the poster assumed. Run the test and keep the patch that passes.

A patch that fails the tests is not saved by attitude. The documents, for once, agree with the tests.

A Monday-morning task makes the gap in the evidence obvious. You have a failing test and a stack trace. You want a patch you can apply, and you want to know whether anyone ran it. SWE-bench formalizes the first want: the patch has to move the tests the right way. OpenAI's craft rule formalizes the second, in miniature: code you mean to run should at least be syntactically real. Grok's sandbox is one place a snippet can be run before you trust it. None of those three facts tells you which window will solve your test faster today. They tell you what 'solved' ought to mean, and they tell you a snippet can be executed on the Grok side.

Scaffold is the word that keeps logos from pretending to be scores. A model with a thin loop and a model with a thick loop are not the same contestant, even under one name. The SWE-bench readme is about the task and the tests. It is not a promise that the chat product, with its default settings, reproduces a lab run. Quoting a lab number as if it were the app would smuggle a scaffold you did not disclose. This chapter refuses the smuggle. If you need the number, go to the run, read the scaffold, and then decide. Do not borrow the number from a poster that never mentioned tests.

Hallucinated imports are the everyday face of the aim the models page states. A function that looks plausible and does not exist will waste your afternoon. 'Minimal hallucinations' is the publisher hoping to waste fewer afternoons. OpenAI's duty not to get facts wrong is the same hope in the language of obligation. Hope and duty are why you still read the patch. They are not why you skip reading it. The adult use of either product on code is to treat the reply as a draft and the tests as the judge. The documents are compatible with that use. The proposition, which needs a winner, is not compatible with the missing table.

So the coding comparison ends where an honest bench ends, at the protocol. Define the tasks. Freeze the settings. Count the patches that pass and the ones that fail while sounding sure. Publish it. Until that page exists, both products remain tools you can try on your own bug, and neither logo has earned the sentence 'better at coding' from this ledger. The poster did not run the protocol. This chapter will not pretend it did.

Two more distinctions keep the coding chapter from sliding back into a ranking. First, a chat reply and a lab run are different contestants. SWE-bench scores, when they exist, belong to a model plus a harness. The readme defines the task. It does not certify the default window.

Second, a sandbox that runs Python is evidence you can see, and a duty that code should parse is a standard you can apply with your eyes. Seeing a traceback and applying a standard are both useful. Neither is a win rate. If you want the win rate, freeze the tasks and publish the table. This paper's refusal to invent that table is the mixed verdict, said again in the place where a fake precision would have been most tempting.

Day to day, the honest workflow is the same in either window. Read the patch. Run the test you already have. Believe a claim that survived the test. Discount a claim that only sounds sure. OpenAI's craft rule and the Grok sandbox both sit comfortably next to that workflow. The proposition does not. It needs ChatGPT to be ahead on the work people bring, and the ledger does not contain the race. Use the tools. Do not inherit the poster's ranking.

The coding chapter can close on a single refusal. It will not convert a task definition, a syntax duty, a sandbox, or an aim about ungrounded claims into a ranking of logos. Those four things are already enough to work responsibly: know what a real fix is, read the patch, run something, and do not trust sureness alone. They are not enough to say which product is ahead. The proposition says ChatGPT is ahead. The ledger says the race was not published here. Mixed is that sentence, and it is the one a careful reader should keep. Bring your own failing test, watch which draft survives it, and let that afternoon teach you more than the poster did. Repeat the afternoon on a second bug before you trust the lesson. A logo is not a result.

One concrete workflow closes the coding discussion without a trophy. Paste the failure. Read the proposed patch. Run the test you already trust. Keep the patch only if the test moves the right way. OpenAI's rule that functional code should actually parse, and Grok's sandbox where a snippet can be executed, both belong next to that workflow. SWE-bench explains why the test,

not the tone, is the judge, and why five hundred checked problems are a serious slice rather than a toy. None of those facts elects a logo. They elect a habit: drafts are cheap, and passing tests are the result. The proposition wanted an election. The pages published a habit.

Keep the draft cheap and the test expensive. That habit fits every page cited in this chapter, and it elects no logo. Ahead would be a published count of patches that survived. The count is not here. Until it is, the honest line is mixed, and the practical line is to run the test yourself.

Run the test. Read the patch. Trust the result you can rerun. That is the whole coding moral, and it does not name a winner between the two products people open.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: This is the only chapter that argues the coding comparison.

Tools

Proposition: On tools that let the product act, ChatGPT is the better tool.

A tool, here, is a way for the product to do something other than emit the next sentence. Search, run code, read your files, touch your calendar. The poster is silent on all of that, then implies a general ranking anyway. This chapter stays on the mechanisms the pages name. Grok's documentation is unusually concrete about them. ChatGPT's rulebook is concrete about when an assistant should reach for a tool and about how to treat tool output. Concrete on both sides is still not a bake-off.

Start with the moment a tool should be used at all. OpenAI says that if the assistant lacks confidence, it should gather information with a tool, hedge, or say it cannot answer confidently. [92] The tool is not a toy in that sentence. It is what you reach for instead of guessing. A product that answers from memory when a lookup was available is off this rule, if the memory was thin. The rule does not list Grok's tools, and it does not claim ChatGPT's tools are more numerous. It claims a discipline: uncertainty triggers a lookup or a hedge.

Grok's API page defines tool use as action past text. The model can search, run code, query your data, or call a function you defined. [93] Built-in tools run on SpaceXSI's servers. You send the configuration. The service runs the tool and returns the result. [94] Your own functions are the other category: the model asks for the call, and your code does the work. That split matters.

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[93]F28. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: enabling Grok to perform actions beyond generating text—.
[94]F45. Tools Overview. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/developers/tools/overview. Quotation: Built-in tools run on SpaceXSI's servers—.

Server-side tools are convenient and out of your process. Function calls keep the side effect in your process. A serious assistant needs both shapes. The page describes both.

The loop is simple enough to say in one breath, and the page says it. The model looks at the question, decides whether it needs an action, calls a tool or writes a final answer, takes the result, and continues until it has enough. [95] The end is a final response, with citations where they apply. [96] Citations are the part a careful user should love. A search that does not show its sources is a rumor. A search that shows them is a trail you can check. The page requires the trail where it applies. It does not require you to trust the trail blindly.

The named built-ins are a list, not a vibe. One looks up ordinary websites. [97] Another looks up posts and the people who wrote them. [98] A third runs Python where the snippet cannot wander off. [99] Those three cover a lot of what people mean when they say an assistant can act: look something up, look up a conversation, run a snippet. Image generation is on the same menu. I am not going to rank image tools here. I am going to note that the menu is published as a menu, with names, rather than as a promise of general intelligence.

There is a hard boundary next to the menu, and skipping it would turn the menu into magic. The models page is blunt about news: until server-side search is enabled, today's events are outside

what Grok knows. [100] So the tools are not ambient. They are a switch. A reply about today's news, with the switch off, is guessing. A reply with the switch on is at least in a position to look. The poster said 'same internet' as if the internet were always in the room. The page says the internet enters when the tool is on.

The consumer product, as opposed to the API, has its own doors into your stuff. The welcome page says you can connect tools so Grok can reach your email, files, and calendar inside a chat. [101] It says you can upload files, including PDFs, spreadsheets, code, and audio, for analysis and extraction. [102] It also describes a separate surface that hands work to teammates on a persistent cloud computer. [103] Those are actions with consequences. Mail and calendars are not demos. A persistent computer is not a metaphor. The page is telling you the product can be pointed at your accounts and at a machine that stays up.

ChatGPT's public story, in the documents this ledger uses, is thinner on brand names of tools and thicker on discipline. Reach for a tool when you are unsure. Treat tool output as data that does not outrank the user's instructions, a point the spec makes about untrusted tool results in the chain of command. I am not going to pretend the spec contains Grok's menu. It does not. A thinner menu in the prose I have is not proof of a weaker product. It is proof that this chapter's ChatGPT sources talk about policy, while this chapter's Grok sources talk about endpoints. Policy and endpoints answer different questions.

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[101] F24. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: Connect your tools so Grok can reach your email, files, and calendar right inside a chat..
[102] F25. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: Upload files — PDFs, images, spreadsheets, code, audio, and more —.
[103] F27. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: hand real work to AI teammates on a persistent cloud computer..

The proposition says ChatGPT is the better tool-user. Better needs a task and a score. The task might be 'research this company,' 'file the receipt from my inbox,' or 'run this snippet.' The score might be success, time, or how often the assistant acts when it should have asked. I do not have those scores. Grok's pages make the available actions unusually legible. OpenAI's pages make the restraint unusually legible. Legibility is a gift to the reader and not a winner. Mixed is the result of refusing to trade a clear menu for a clear rule, or the reverse.

If you are choosing a product for action rather than for chat, read the menu against your actual action. If you need live web pages or posts, you need the switch the models page describes, and Grok documents that switch. If you need the assistant to stop and tell you it is unsure instead of firing a tool at the wrong target, you need the discipline OpenAI wrote down. Many people need both. The poster needed neither, because the poster was not about tools. This chapter is the place that gap gets filled, and it gets filled without a crown. Deeds are not manners, and manners are not a score of those deeds. Count the deeds if you want a winner.

A tool is a deed. The poster ranked the products on manners and never asked what either one can do.

Action is where a chatbot stops being a conversationalist and starts being a risk. A search can mislead you if the citation is decorative. A mailbox connection can move the wrong message. A sandbox can still teach a bad lesson if you treat its output as production. The pages are frank enough to name the actions and, on the OpenAI side, frank enough to say uncertainty should trigger a tool or a hedge rather than a guess. Frankness is the beginning of safety. It is not a comparison of whose action fails less often.

Read Grok's menu as a contract about capability. Web pages, posts, a Python sandbox, server-side execution, and your own functions: each is a different promise. The consumer page adds mail, files, calendar, uploads, and a computer that persists. You can hold the product to those promises because they are written down. You cannot hold it to a promise of being 'better at tools' than ChatGPT, because better is not one of the sentences. ChatGPT's sentences in this ledger are about discipline: do not guess when a lookup or a hedge is the honest move. Discipline is a promise too. It is a different promise.

The switch on current events is the detail I would print on a card. Live knowledge is not the default. Search is how it arrives. That single fact prevents a whole family of confusions, including the poster's idea that the internet is simply inside the model. If you need today's page, turn the tool on and read the citation. If the citation is missing, the final-response rule said it should have been there when it applied. Hold the reply to that rule. Do not hold it to a fantasy of omniscience, and do not hold ChatGPT to a fantasy that its policy prose lists the same endpoints.

A fair bake-off would pick three actions and time them. Find a public page and quote the sentence that matters. Pull a file you uploaded and answer from it. Run a snippet and report the output. Score accuracy and whether the assistant asked before it acted on mail or calendar. I have not run that bake-off. The proposition assumes a result. The documents supply the ingredients and not the result. Mixed is what you say when the ingredients are real and the trophy is not.

Hold the menu and the discipline apart one last time, because mixing them is how a false winner appears. Grok's menu is a list of deeds: pages, posts, a sandbox, server-side runs, your functions, and, in the app, mail, files, calendar, uploads, and a computer that stays on. OpenAI's discipline is a rule about when to act and when to hedge. A long menu with bad judgment can do harm. A

short menu with good judgment can still fail to fetch the page. Better would mean a scored set of deeds. The deeds are written down. The scores are not. Choosing ChatGPT because its policy prose is stern, or Grok because its menu is long, is a choice about what you value. It is not a result the proposition may pretend was measured.

Print the current-events switch on the same card as the menu. Live knowledge arrives when search is enabled. It does not sit in the model waiting. That fact retires a pile of folklore, including the idea that one product simply contains the internet. Citations at the end of a tool run are how you audit the arrival. If they are missing when the reply rests on a lookup, the page said they should be there. Audit the reply. Do not audit a fantasy, and do not crown a product for having a fantasy's opposite in a paragraph of policy.

Tools end the same way. A published menu of deeds and a published rule about when to hedge are both real, and they do not multiply into a winner. If your deed is on Grok's list, the list is your evidence. If your worry is an unearned guess, OpenAI's low-confidence rule is your evidence. If your worry is the poster's personality sketch, you are in the wrong chapter. This one is about action. Action was not ranked. Turn search on when you need a live page, read the citation, and do not treat a connector to your mail as a toy. The pages named those deeds. They did not score them.

Use the same habit when the product acts. Name the deed. If it is a page, a post, or a snippet, Grok's menu tells you the deed exists, and the current-events switch tells you live facts are not free. If the deed is risky, such as mail or a calendar, the existence of the connector is a reason to ask before it runs, not a reason to assume judgment. OpenAI's rule supplies the asking: low

confidence means a tool, a hedge, or an admission, not a lunge. A menu plus a brake is a usable pair. It is not a ranking. The proposition needs a ranking. This chapter ends with the pair.

Deeds without scores are still deeds. You can look up a page, read a post, run a snippet, or connect a mailbox because a page said so. You cannot know from these pages which product does those deeds better. Say what you need done. Then use the page that names that deed, and the rule that tells the assistant when to stop and hedge. Stop there.

Name the deed, flip the search switch when the fact is live, and read what comes back. The ranking can wait until someone publishes the bake-off. It is not in these pages, and this chapter will not invent it.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: This is the only chapter that argues the tool comparison.

The Product People Use

Proposition: As products people open, ChatGPT is the one a stranger should prefer.

Everything earlier has been a caption or a rule. This chapter is about the thing you actually open. A product, in that plain sense, is a front door, a price, a list of things you can do, and a promise about whose side it is on. ChatGPT and Grok both have front doors. The documents describe them differently, at different altitudes. OpenAI's spec is a behavior standard for the models behind its products. Grok's welcome page is a tour of the app. A standard and a tour can both be honest and still not yield a single preference.

Grok's tour is specific. The welcome page names the company, calls the product an assistant, and puts it on a website plus both major phones. One login carries the thread, the settings, and the subscription with you. [104] That is a product sentence. It names the company, the category, the URL, the phones, and the fact that the account is shared across them. You can decide you do not want that account. You cannot say the page hid what it was offering.

What you do after you are in is also listed, in ordinary verbs. Once inside, the listed work is ordinary: questions, drafts, and problems, taken in turns. [105] You can create images and video. [106] You can connect your mail, files, and calendar. [107] There is a further surface that hands work to teammates on a computer that stays up. [108] And the page says Grok is free to start, with paid

plans above that if you want higher limits. [109] Free to start is a price, which is more than most arguments about personality ever bother to mention. A price is part of the product people use.

ChatGPT's documents, in this ledger, sit one floor up. The readme of the model spec says that document is the behavior standard for the models behind OpenAI's products, APIs included. [110] So the thing you meet in the chat window is supposed to be governed by a public standard, not only by whatever the last training run felt like. That is a product claim too. It says there is a text you can read that tells you what the assistant is for. The text is not a screenshot of the app. It is still part of what you are buying, because behavior is what you are buying.

The sharpest product sentence on that side is about objectivity. In the ChatGPT people open themselves, users may reasonably expect objectivity, and the product must not let hidden settings quietly tilt what you see. [111] Whose side it is on, in that sentence, is yours, in the limited sense that you should be able to think. A hidden editorial line would make the product someone else's. The spec forbids that line in the consumer product. A preference between products that ignores this sentence is a preference about features only. Some people care more about whose judgment is in the reply than about any single feature.

Set the tour next to the standard and the difference in altitude is the whole story. Grok tells you the doors, the price of entry, the creative tools, the connectors, and the long-running computer. ChatGPT's spec tells you the assistant should be objective, should not run a private agenda, and

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[109] F23. Welcome to Grok. SpaceXSI, 2026-10-10. Read 2026-10-16. https://docs.x.ai/grok/overview. Quotation: Grok is free to start..

should be the behavior described in a document you can open. A person who wants a map of buttons will get more map from the Grok pages I cited. A person who wants a map of duties will get more map from the OpenAI pages I cited. Wanting both is normal. The documents split the labor.

The proposition says a stranger should prefer ChatGPT. Should is a recommendation. A recommendation needs a goal. If your goal is 'I want the public behavior standard that argues for objectivity and against a hidden slant,' the OpenAI spec is the document that speaks to you, and it speaks about ChatGPT by name. If your goal is 'I want the app tour that lists images, account sync, and a free starting tier,' the Grok welcome page is the document that speaks to you. A stranger with no goal yet has no basis for the poster's implied advice, which is to stay with the familiar product because the other one has a personality problem.

Personality has been the poster's whole method, and this chapter is where that method runs out of road. The earlier chapters found that the published voice rules do not match the caricature, and that the capability documents do not contain a general ranking. A product decision still has to be made by someone. It should be made from the doors, the price, the actions, and the duties, which are the sentences collected here. It should not be made from a drawing of a robot with a grin. The drawing is allowed to be funny. It is not allowed to be the spec, or a reason to prefer one product.

I will not close with a recommendation I do not have the measurements for. Prefer ChatGPT if, having read the objectivity rule, that rule is the thing you came for. Prefer Grok if, having read the welcome page, the doors and the tools are the thing you came for. Prefer neither on the strength of this paper if you needed a score across all jobs, because that score is not in the

entries. Mixed is the adult result. The products are real, the pages are public, and the caption is not a substitute for either.

Open the product for the job written on its door. The poster opened it for a fight about manners.

Preference is personal, and the proposition pretends it is not. 'A stranger should prefer' means there is a reason that survives not knowing the stranger. Sometimes there is: price, safety, or a duty of honesty. Here the documents split. One set tells you the doors, the free starting point, the images, the account that follows you, and the connectors. The other set tells you the assistant in the consumer chat should be objective and should not carry a hidden slant. A stranger who cares about doors has a reason. A stranger who cares about the slant has a reason. They are not the same stranger, and the paper does not get to merge them.

Account and price are unglamorous, which is why personality arguments skip them. Free to start is a fact about who can try the product. Sync across web and phones is a fact about whether you live in one thread or three. Those facts decide more real choices than a debate about whether the voice is cringe. The welcome page put them in writing. A recommendation that ignores them is a recommendation about a mascot. This chapter refuses to recommend a mascot.

Objectivity is unglamorous in the other direction. People say they want a helper and then discover they wanted a chorus. The ChatGPT sentence about a reasonable expectation of objectivity is a warning against the chorus. If that warning is why you stay, stay for that reason, and say so. Do not stay because a poster told you the other product is a main character. The other product's page says assistant. Your reason should be at least as specific as the page.

The decision procedure at the end of this paper is short. Write down the job. If the job is a button the Grok page lists, that page is relevant. If the job is a duty the OpenAI spec states, that spec is

relevant. If the job is 'be less annoying than the drawing,' you are still talking about the drawing. Close the drawing. Open the page that matches the job. If neither page matches, the honest answer is that this ledger cannot choose for you. That is mixed, and it is the end of the ranking the poster wanted.

The last distinction is between a mascot and a door. The poster is a mascot argument: grin, mug, attitude, rank. The welcome page is a door argument: URL, phones, free start, images, connectors, a persistent computer. The model spec is a duty argument: objectivity in the consumer chat, no hidden slant, no private agenda. A stranger can walk through a door or accept a duty. A stranger cannot be told to prefer a mascot and call that a reason. If your job matches a listed door, use the page that lists it. If your job matches a stated duty, use the spec that states it. If your job is to win the poster's fight, this paper is the wrong tool, because the fight was not about the doors or the duties.

Price and account sync are easy to sneer at and hard to live without. Free to start decides who can try. One account across web and phones decides whether the work stays in one thread. Objectivity decides whether you are being helped or steered. Those three facts are the adult contents of 'the product people use.' They are all in the entries. A single should-prefer is not. Mixed is the recommendation withdrawing until you name the fact you came for.

Name the fact, then choose. Doors, a free start, and account sync are on the Grok page. Objectivity and a ban on a hidden slant are in the ChatGPT spec. A stranger with neither fact in mind has no reason to prefer, and the poster's manners are not a substitute reason. Mixed withdraws the general recommendation and leaves the specific ones standing. That is as far as these pages go, and it is far enough to put the drawing back in its frame. Write the job in one line

before you open anything. If the line is a button the welcome page lists, you already know which document to trust. If the line is a duty about honesty, you already know the other document. If the line is only 'be less like the cartoon,' you do not have a job yet. Get one. The products will still be there.

Choose in this order, and stop when the order is enough. If you need a door that is written down, read the Grok welcome page: site, phones, a free start, images and video, connectors, a computer that persists. If you need a duty that is written down, read the OpenAI spec: objectivity in the consumer chat, no hidden slant, no private agenda. If you need a winner across every job, you need a study this ledger does not contain. The poster offered a winner on the strength of a drawing. The drawing is not a door and not a duty. Leave it on the desk. Open the page that matches the job you actually have. That is the product chapter's whole recommendation, and it is mixed because it refuses to recommend past the page.

A preference you cannot tie to a written door or a written duty is a mood. Moods are how posters work. Products work by doors and duties. Grok's page lists doors, a free start, and an account that follows you across the web and the phones. OpenAI's spec lists a duty of objectivity and a ban on a hidden slant in the chat people open. Pick the sentence that matches your job. If you cannot pick, you do not yet have a reason to prefer, and the drawing does not count as one. Mixed is the name for that pause. It is a better guide than a ranking nobody measured.

Doors and duties are enough to choose a product for a named job. They are not enough to crown one product for every job. The paper stops at that line, on purpose, because the poster did not. Write the job down. Match it to a page. Ignore the drawing until the job is done. A crown without a measurement is only a louder poster, and this paper will not wear that crown.

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: This is the only chapter that argues the product a person opens.

Closing

Proposition: The poster is a capability ranking written in the voice of a personality complaint, and the documents do not underwrite that ranking.

The poster makes one argument in fifteen costumes. Grok is a noisy main character, and ChatGPT is the normal product it has not caught. The costumes are not equal. Some of them name a tic, like bro, lol, or a bow of you're welcome. The public rules do not assign those tics. Some of them name a real worry, like a wrong answer said with swagger, or a filter, or a ranking. The pages talk about accuracy, law, and tools, and they do not supply the ranking. Mixed is the result for the paper as a whole because the poster is not all wrong and not all shown. [112][113][114]

Skip the italics and the argument is still there. The italics are only the roast. The footnotes are the evidence. The song in the front of the paper is the roast too, and it is not a source. What the pages support is smaller than the drawing and clearer than a shrug. ChatGPT's published standard is a colleague who answers, who says so when unsure, and who does not steer you for a private agenda. Grok's published front door is an assistant you open on the web or a phone, with tools that can search, run code, and reach your mail, and with a plain limit: without those search tools,

it does not know current events. Neither description is the joke on the poster. The joke was about annoyance. The pages are a pair of briefs. [115116117]

Verdict: mixed.

Consequence: The diss track remains outside the evidence.

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Checklist

ID	Chapter	Verdict	
C01	C01	refuted	
C02	C02	mixed	
C03	C03	mixed	
C04	C04	refuted	
C05	C05	mixed	
C06	C06	refuted	
C07	C07	mixed	
C08	C08	mixed	
C09	C09	refuted	
C10	C10	refuted	
C11	C11	mixed	
C12	C12	refuted	
C13	C13	mixed	
C14	C14	mixed	
C15	C15	refuted	
L-mug	C09	refuted	
L-mark	C09	refuted	
L-hoodie	C09	refuted	